

MARVEL
SPIDER-MAN
Homecoming

英文原版
电影同名小说

蜘蛛侠：英雄归来

美国漫威公司◎著



英文原版. Spider-Man: Homecoming 蜘蛛侠：英雄归来(电影同名小说)

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Prologue ◀



2009

Adrian Toomes and his crew were working in the shadow of Avengers Tower, cleaning up the aftermath of the Battle of New York. Pieces of Chitauri vehicles and armor and other stuff Toomes didn't recognize were scattered for blocks across midtown. It was a good contract. He had a lot invested in it. But right then, he was showing one of his crew members, Mason, a drawing his daughter had done. "The world is changing. You got guys who can fly, tear down buildings...." The drawing showed Iron Man and the Hulk. "Can you believe this stuff?" Mason started to answer, but Toomes was distracted by one of his men trying to saw through the housing of a wrecked Chitauri flier.

"No, no, look," he said, hustling over to pick up another piece of the flier. "You can't cut through that stuff with a saw. These alien things are tough....You gotta use the stuff they use." He wedged the piece of alloy under part of the housing and popped it off. Then he did it again to make sure the lesson stuck. "See?"

Then he noticed another member of his crew, the kid Brice, strolling in with a cup of coffee in his hand. Late as always. “Glad you could join us!”

Brice locked eyes with Toomes. “What?” He was always cocky. Toomes already regretted hiring him.

Toomes let it go. “Just get started stacking that armor plating, okay?”

Things were starting to roll. The crew was loading a lot of Chitauri salvage onto trucks. In another few weeks the building would be clear and other contractors would move in to rebuild it. There were scenes like this all over New York.

Toomes heard a voice call from across the work site. “Attention, please!” He looked up. A group of men in suits, with a woman in a suit leading them in. The suits weren’t good. They looked like government.

When she kept talking, he learned he was right. “In accordance with Executive Order 396-B, all post-battle cleanup operations are now under our jurisdiction! Thank you for your service—we’ll take it from here.”

“Who are you?” Toomes demanded.

“Qualified personnel,” one of the suits next to the woman said with a smirk. Toomes was having a bad enough day without this guy laughing at him.

“Look, ma’am, I have a salvage contract with the city,” Toomes said. He put on a smile, trying to be personable. “If there’s an issue, we can call Frank Desalvo’s office in City Planning.”

Unmoved, she said, “Please turn over any and all exotic materials you’ve collected. Or you’ll be prosecuted.”



Toomes leaned in closer, speaking more quietly. “Come on, please....I bought trucks for this job, put on more guys. They’ve got families. So do I. I’m all in on this thing. You pull the plug, I’m gonna lose my house....”

He thought he saw a flicker of sympathy in her eyes, but all she said was, “I don’t know what to tell you, sir.”

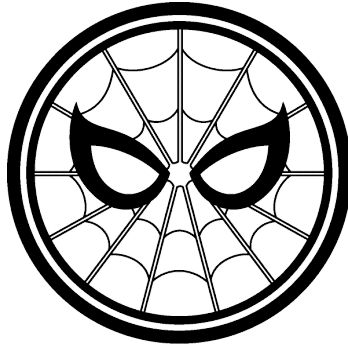
“Maybe next time don’t overextend yourself,” added the suit next to her.

That was it. Toomes lost his temper and punched the suit square in the jaw. All the other suits drew guns almost instantly. Toomes’s crew picked up crowbars and other tools. They were loyal and tough. It was a standoff...until the woman raised one hand and motioned for her men to lower their guns.

“If you have a grievance,” she said, “you can take it up with my superiors.”

“And who is that?” Toomes asked.

Of course it turned out to be Tony Stark.



Later, Toomes and his crew sat in the garage near the work site, nursing drinks and watching a TV news report about the new arrangement that had cost all of them their jobs. “A joint venture between Stark Industries and the federal government, the newly created Department of Damage Control, will oversee collection and storage of alien and other exotic materials,” a talking head was saying.

“So now the guys who made this mess get paid to clean it up,” Toomes said bitterly.

“It’s all rigged,” Schultz said.

Mason, who was tinkering with a small piece of alien tech he’d swiped from the site, raised his drink. “To the little guy! Who works hard, pays his dues, and always gets it in the end!”

They cheered, but none of them was happy.

Some of the other guys were still working. One of them, Ford, pulled a tarp from one of the trucks, revealing a pile of Chitauri tech. “Hey, chief,” he called. “We still got a load from yesterday. We’re supposed to turn it in, right?”

“I’m not hauling it,” Brice said. Other guys murmured in agreement.

Toomes wasn’t sure what to do. On the one hand, this new Damage Control outfit had ordered him to turn in all his salvage material. On the other hand...

He looked at his daughter's drawings on the corkboard over his desk. What would she do if Toomes came home broke, without even any prospects for a new job? Why should Tony Stark make money off reconstruction when he'd made the mess in the first place?

Toomes started to get an idea. "Put it in Mason's workshop."

Mason perked up. He was practically a wizard with any kind of machine.

"Oh, great," Brice said. "At least the weirdo's got some garbage to tinker with."

"Shut up," Toomes said. Brice stood and faced him defiantly. But Toomes didn't back down. This was his crew. "The world's changing," he said. "It's time we change, too."



Chapter 01



2017

Peter Parker sat in the back of Tony Stark's car...with Tony Stark actually sitting next to him! His driver, Happy Hogan, was making his way through the streets toward Peter's neighborhood in Queens, New York. Peter had spent most of the ride from the airport watching video he'd recorded of his crazy trip to Germany. He still couldn't believe it was all real, and watching it happen on his phone made it seem even crazier.

There he was on-screen, in this same car with Happy driving, on the way to the airport. He narrated the trip in a cool, dramatic, heroic voice until Happy cut him off. Happy was kind of a sourpuss. Peter rewatched the first time he'd seen Tony Stark's plane—whoa! Then the first time he'd seen his new Spider-Man suit—DOUBLE WHOA! The suit was way better than the one he had made for himself.

Then the Leipzig airport, where he'd waited for Tony Stark to give him his signal. (He didn't love the signal itself, but hey, if someone *had* to call you "Underoos," at least it was Tony Stark!)

Then the fight! He'd seen the Vision fly by, wrestled with Ant-Man...and even yanked Captain America's shield right out of his hand!

Man, it was hard to believe it was happening to someone like Peter Parker, who had spent most of his young life as just a regular kid from Queens. Even now, on the way back, Peter kept shooting video just so he could always remember it.

“Are you secretly filming me?” Tony asked.

“What?” Peter put his phone down. “No. I mean...”

“I told you not to film stuff!” Happy called from the driver’s seat. “I told him, Tony.”

Tony moved on. “It’s fine. We should make a video for your aunt anyway. Rolling?”

“Uh, yeah.” Peter held up his phone so Tony was centered in the frame.

“Ready?” Tony said. Peter nodded. “Hi, May. What are you wearing?” Then he stopped. “Inappropriate, start over. You can edit this, right?”

“Uh, yeah,” Peter said again.

Tony started over. “Hello, May. I just wanted to tell you what an incredible job your nephew did this weekend at the Stark internship retreat. Your Peter made quite an impression—”

He was cut off by Happy leaning on the Bentley’s horn and shouting at other drivers. “Stay in your lane!”

Tony looked up at him, and then back to Peter. “So how did he do?”



“Okay, I guess,” Happy said.

“No, I’m asking him how you did.” Now Happy looked offended. Tony was focused on Peter, though. “Took good care of you? Didn’t snore too loud on the plane? You know, this was a big responsibility for him.”

Suddenly being the focus of all of Tony Stark’s attention made Peter nervous. “Oh, um, yeah, he did fine....”

Happy swerved the car to a hard stop in front of Peter’s building. “We’re here! End of the line, kid.”

Still focused on Peter, Tony said, “Happy, can you give us a moment?”

“Seriously?” Happy couldn’t believe it. “You want me to leave the car?”

“Yeah. Maybe get Peter’s case out of the trunk,” Tony replied.

“Oh, I’m carrying his bags now? Unbelievable...” Still grumbling, Happy went around to the trunk.

Peter replayed Tony’s last line in his head. “My case?” he repeated. The idea stunned him. “I get to keep the suit?” Peter asked, just to make sure.

“Of course,” Stark said. “You earned it.”

Peter still couldn’t quite believe his own camera footage, let alone that he could actually keep the most high-tech piece of equipment he had ever seen.

“Don’t do anything I wouldn’t do. And definitely don’t do anything I would do. There’s a little gray area there. That’s where you operate.”

“Thank you, Mr. Stark! So does this mean...I’m...an Aven—” Peter couldn’t quite make himself say it. Happy knocked on the window. Peter looked and saw Happy holding up the case containing the new Spider-Suit.

“It’s fine; I can carry it,” Peter said. “So when’s our next... retreat?”

“We’ll call you,” Tony answered. He leaned toward Peter, and Peter, surprised, but happy, gave him a hug.

“Not hugging you,” Stark said. “Just opening the door.” He sat back, and Peter got out. After a pause, Stark added, “Bye.”

The Bentley drove off, and Peter, holding the case with his new Spider-Man outfit, watched it go. “They’re gonna call

me,” he said to himself, amazed at the way his life had changed.

Peter was understandably disappointed when months went by and nobody called.



Chapter 02



Every time Peter's phone rang and he didn't recognize the number, he answered it like it was a call from the Avengers....And every time it was like a personal rejection.

Two months, three months, four months. Peter rode the subway to school as everyone else did, sometimes watching videos from Leipzig or from the flight over on Tony Stark's private jet. For just those couple of days, he'd been part of a different world.

And now he was stuck back in his ordinary world.

On this morning, like every other morning, he got off the subway and jogged down the stairs from the elevated tracks to the street. He joined the crowd of overachievers headed into the Midtown School of Science & Technology, still watching his phone. That nearly got him run over when Flash Thompson came rolling into the parking lot in his new car. "'Sup, Parker!" Flash called out.

Luckily, Flash was so busy giving Peter a hard time that he hadn't noticed Peter jumped out of his way a little *too* fast. *Good*, Peter thought. It wasn't always easy to hide his Spider-Man abilities. He went inside, put his phone away, and started fiddling with the combination on his locker. A moment later, he heard his friend Ned pretending to be a movie villain—Ned wasn't the best at impressions. "Join me, and together, we will build my new toy!"

Spinning around, Peter said, "No way! How many pieces?"

Ned grinned. "Three thousand eight hundred and three."

"Insane," Peter said. Peter and Ned had been building these sets together for ages.

"I know! Wanna build it tonight?"

Peter definitely did. But he needed to keep waiting for the call from Tony Stark and for the chance to prove he could be an Avenger. “I can’t,” he said. “I got the—”

“Stark internship,” Ned said, his face falling. “You’ve always got the internship.”

“Yeah, and pretty soon it’s going to lead to a real job with him.” He secretly meant being one of the Avengers, but Ned, of course, didn’t know that.

Ned was happy for his friend anyway. “That would be so sweet, working for Iron Man!” Ned said. “He’d be all, ‘Good job on your spreadsheets, Peter! Here, have a gold coin!’” Then he stopped, seeing Peter’s expression. “I don’t really know how jobs work.”

Peter laughed. “No, I’m sure that’s exactly right.”

“So I’ll knock out the basic bones at home, then swing by your place to finish it,” Ned suggested.

Peter was going to say no, but then he got distracted. Liz walked by with her friend Betty as they were talking over details of planning the Homecoming dance. “Sounds good,” he said absently. To Peter, Liz was amazing. She was smart, popular, gorgeous, and even friendly to nerds like him and Ned. She glanced over at him and smiled, then returned to her conversation. Peter felt like he could live on that smile for the rest of his life.

Ned was still talking, but the bell rang and Peter had to get to class.

In physics, Ms. Warren was drawing a diagram with a series of equations on the board. Peter tried to pay attention but found himself watching old videos of the Avengers' fight with the Chitauri invaders in New York. He clicked over to videos of himself. Not nearly as many views as the Avengers video, and under most of them the first comment was *FAKE!!!!*

Ms. Warren finished the equation and turned to the class. "Now, how about calculating thrust? Where do we start?" Flash Thompson raised his hand. "Yes, Flash?"

"With the binomial."

Ms. Warren smiled. "Peter? Still with us?"

Peter looked up from the screen, closing his laptop. She could have busted him if she'd wanted to, but Ms. Warren usually cut him a break. Right away he saw what Flash had missed. "Uh...thrust? Yeah, the negatives cancel each other out, so solve for x , then determine the binomial."

"Right as always," Ms. Warren said with a proud smile.

Flash stared daggers at Peter, but what was Peter supposed to do? The right answer was the right answer.

At lunch he and Ned sat together at one of the tables far at the back of the cafeteria. At the other end of the room, Liz and Betty were hanging a Homecoming banner. The dance was coming up soon, but Peter hadn't given it much thought. Liz, on the other hand...her, he gave a lot of thought.

“Did Liz get a new top?” he asked.

“No, we’ve seen that before,” Ned said. “But never with that skirt.”

“We should stop staring before it gets creepy,” Peter said.

“Too late,” said Michelle from the other end of the table. She’d just sat down. “You two are such losers.”

“Then why do you sit with us?”

“‘Cause I don’t have any friends,” she said, completely matter-of-fact. “Plus, we’re having Decathlon practice during lunch.”

“What?” Peter hadn’t known about this, but here came the rest of the Academic Decathlon team, Liz, Flash, all the others; they’d formed a sort of academic mob.

“If you’re gonna flake on every practice after school, Parker, we’ll just practice during school,” Liz said.

Flash, standing with the rest of the team, said, “I can’t believe we’re catering to him. We don’t need this dork.”

“As team captain, I disagree,” Liz said. “If we’re gonna win nationals, we need every dork at this table.”

“Let’s get to dork!” Ned said. They all just looked at him. “Like get to work...?” he added hopefully.

“Oh, we got it,” Michelle said. Her tone made it clear she didn’t think it was funny.

Peter took a deep breath. He'd been trying to avoid this, but now there was no way around it. "About nationals," he said softly. "I can't go."

Everyone except Flash was surprised and upset. "Why?" Liz asked.

"I'm..." Peter started. *Because I'm Spider-Man*, he thought. *And I have to meet that responsibility first.* But he couldn't ever say that out loud. "I'm just too busy."

"Doing what?" Michelle asked. "You already quit Computer Club and Robotics Lab." She looked around at the rest of the team. "I'm not obsessed with him. I'm just very observant."

"You can't bail before nationals! We don't have anyone as strong as you on physics."



"You have Flash," Peter said.

"Neil deGrasse Tyson got nuttin' on me!" Flash said.

It was true that Flash was good in physics...but not as good as Peter. Liz and the rest of the team didn't look confident.

Peter leaned closer to Liz and quietly said, "They wouldn't do a physics challenge two years in a row." Then, to everyone, he added, "Sorry, everybody. Good luck."

He got up and started to walk across the cafeteria. Liz came after him. "Peter, look, I get it," she said. "It's hard to juggle everything. When I was a sophomore, I struggled, too. We were counting on you."

"I'm sorry," Peter said. He didn't know what else to say.

"Don't you want to go to DC? The White House? Stay in a hotel?"

"I do," Peter said. And he really, really did. Especially if it was with her. "But...I can't."

Then he kept walking, feeling awful about it but knowing that his responsibilities as Spider-Man were more important than anything he wanted to be doing in high school. If he was ever going to be an Avenger, he had to prove himself.



Chapter 03



In his next-to-last class that day—chemistry—Peter stole some time from his regular lab work to tinker on his side project. In a cabinet under the lab table, he had a nice little setup for making web fluid. He poured it carefully into his specially designed cartridges when Mr. Cobwell wasn't looking, and then he stared at the clock, willing it to reach 3:00, when the bell would ring.

When the bell finally chimed, Peter ran to his locker, grabbed his backpack, and rushed out of Midtown with the rest of the students. He cut across the grounds and—after a quick check to make sure no one was looking—leaped over a fence, heading for his favorite bodega, Dalmar's. Spider-Man needed a snack if he was going to fight crime.

He slapped a bag of gummi worms on the counter in front of Mr. Dalmar, who greeted him. "Hey, Pete! The number five, right?"

"Yeah, with pickles, smushed down real flat, please." The sandwich was going to get smushed anyway.

He paid for his food and raced across the street and into an alley. When he was out of sight of the street, he pulled the Spider-Suit from his backpack and struggled into it. In his excitement to get to work, he lost track of which leg he was starting with and lost his balance, falling over into some of the garbage that littered the alley. But he got the suit on, settling baggily over his shoulders. When he tapped the spider-symbol on his chest, the suit activated, fitting itself to his skin. He heard the faint sounds of its circuitry powering up.

He was almost ready. He webbed his backpack to the side of a dumpster and stuffed the sandwich into his boot. Then he crawled up the alley wall to a ledge that stuck out from the third floor of the building. From there, he could see most of the neighborhood.



“Hey!” a street vendor called from the corner. “You’re that spider guy on YouTube! Do a flip!”

“Only if you call me Spider-Man,” Peter called back.

“Okay, Spider-Man!”

Peter obliged and casually did a flip, landing again on the narrow ledge. The vendor cheered. Then Peter went back to scanning the area. It was time to get to work.

He heard a scream and almost jumped into action...only to find a waiter startled by a rat as he took out the trash

behind a restaurant down the block. No major crime there, although rats living so close to a restaurant had to be a minor violation of some kind.

Then he heard gunshots! Peter snapped a web out and swung across the street, landing on the roof of a building and running in the direction of the shots. He crept closer to the sound...and saw it was just kids playing a video game with the volume turned up way too loud. Another false alarm.

As he shook his head in disappointment, he heard a loud mechanical sound come from the street just below him. He looked down and saw someone in the alley below trying to break into a car.

Aha! A crime! Peter shot a line of web out and stuck the thief's hand to the door. "Gah!" the thief cried. "Gross!" He pulled at the webbing, but he couldn't get free.

"I'm pretty sure you're not allowed to do that," Peter said. "The cops'll fill you in on the details when they get here." He dropped into the alley and gave the car a rap with his knuckles, hard enough to set off the alarm.

"This is my car!" the thief—who maybe wasn't a thief?—shouted over the noise. "I locked my keys inside!"

Spider-Man glanced through the window. Sure enough, a set of keys dangled from the car's ignition.

Oh man, this was mega-embarrassing.

Neighbors opened their windows to complain about the noise. “Every day with these alarms!” an old man on the second floor griped.

“Sorry!” Spider-Man said. “I thought...” There was no way to explain it. He shot out a web and leaped away.

After that debacle, Peter was more careful. He patrolled the neighborhood, not acting unless he was sure he’d actually seen a crime. The only criminal he caught was a bike thief he left dangling from a web over the sidewalk. But he didn’t know who the bike belonged to, so he left it leaning against a lamppost with a stern note: *Is this your bike? If not, don’t steal it!—Spider-Man*

By sunset, he decided it was time to have that sandwich. He sat on the edge of a building with his mask raised up to his nose and ate slowly, wishing he had something more important to do than catch bike thieves and do flips for sidewalk vendors. Just as he did every evening, he called Happy Hogan to report in. Happy never answered, but Peter wanted to make sure the Avengers didn’t forget about him.

“Hi, Happy,” he said after waiting for Happy’s voice mail. “Here’s my report for the night. I stopped a grand theft... bicycle. Couldn’t find the owner, so I left a note. Oh, and I helped a lost old Dominican lady who was really nice and bought me a churro. But I really think I could be doing a lot more. Just curious when we’re gonna have our next real mission. Call me back. It’s Peter Parker.”

He hung up and immediately wished he hadn't added the bit about the churro. Why would Happy care about that?

The fill soon light on one of his web shooters was red. Peter decided to take care of it right away, so it would be ready for tomorrow. He grabbed a fresh cartridge from his belt and then almost immediately fumbled it. Before it could fall to the street, he shot out a foot and kicked it up, then lunged straight out into empty space to catch it. He hung there for a second, planking straight out over the street with only his feet on the wall. When he was doing stuff like that, it was pretty cool being Spider-Man.

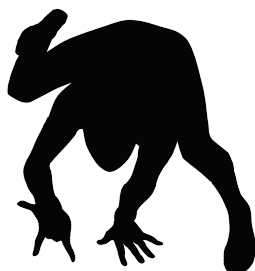
Motion down at the street level caught his attention. An ATM booth was across the street, and four guys were inside. Peter's eyes narrowed, and the eyes on his Spider-Man mask focused. They were wearing Avengers masks. Four guys in masks in an ATM booth? Now, this looked like a real crime.

One of them, in a Hulk mask, pulled something that looked like a gun from a duffel bag. He aimed it at the ATM, and a bright purple beam shot out of it, cutting into the ATM like it was butter. Peter dropped down to the street, ran across, and slid through the booth door without anyone noticing. A guy in a Captain America mask had another weird-looking instrument. He used it to pull the front of the ATM away with some kind of antigravity beam. Then, with faux-Iron Man standing watch, impostor-Thor started stuffing money into another duffel bag.

Peter thought this was the moment he should announce his presence. "Is this a bad time to ask for autographs?"



Chapter 04



The four masked men spun to see Spider-Man right there with them in the booth. Thor and Iron Man immediately pulled out weapons. Iron Man had a shotgun, and Thor a

pistol. Before they could shoot, Spider-Man yanked the shotgun out of Iron Man's hands and swung it like a baseball bat, knocking the pistol out of Thor's grip. "I'm starting to think you guys aren't the real Avengers," he said.

He shot a web at Iron Man that went wide and landed on a desk behind the action. Iron Man started to come after Spider-Man, but Spider-Man gave his line a yank, and the desk crashed into Iron Man, knocking him flat. "Oh, sorry, I didn't mean to do that so hard," Spider-Man said. He meant it sincerely.

But the robbers weren't at all worried about hurting him. Cap still held the antigrav device. He swung it around and hit a switch. The floating chunk of the ATM, hundreds of pounds of steel, shot across the booth at Spider-Man. "Whoa!" he shouted, dodging. The hunk of steel cracked the bulletproof glass behind him. "Cool! What is that?" He webbed the device and pulled it out of Cap's hands, unable to stop himself from checking it out. "How did you guys end up with tech like this? I mean, no offense, you seem great, but—"

The alarm on his phone went off. "Ooh, that's my curfew," Spider-Man said. "We should probably wrap this up."

He kicked Cap across the booth and into the open front of the ATM. Cash exploded from the machine as all four robbers went after him, but they were no match for Spider-Man. In a few seconds they were all on the floor and he was barely breathing hard. He bent over and pulled off Iron Man's mask. "How did you guys pick your masks?" he asked. "Like, what if two of you wanted to be Thor?"



This distraction nearly got him killed, as the Hulk had gotten up and grabbed the cutting tool again while Peter was looking at the Iron Man mask. He leveled it at Spider-Man, who dove aside at the last second. The cutting beam blew through the bulletproof glass and lanced across the street, tearing through a parked car and blasting through the front windows of Mr. Dalmar's bodega.

The recoil knocked all the robbers down, and Spider-Man staggered to his feet to see the bodega burning and debris crashing down onto the sidewalk. "Mr. Dalmar!" he shouted. He ran across the street and into the wrecked bodega. Mr. Dalmar was dazed and trapped under fallen shelves. Spider-Man pulled him free and got him out onto the sidewalk.

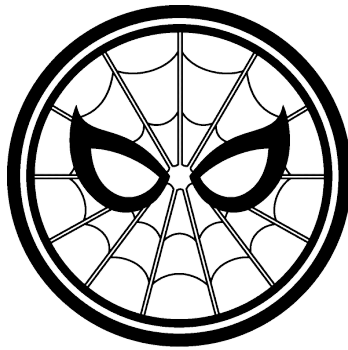
When he looked across the street again, the robbers were gone. First-responder sirens sounded from every direction.

And to top it all off, his curfew alarm was going off again.

Peter was conflicted. He'd stopped a real robbery and found guys using crazy tech that had to be illegal. On the other hand, Mr. Dalmar's bodega was in ruins, and at least two cars were on fire that he could see.

Being a Super Hero was way trickier than Peter had anticipated.

The sirens were getting closer. He had to get out of there before the police arrived. And he had to call Happy.



Surprisingly, Happy answered his phone. He was shouting at someone about something; Peter couldn't tell what.

"Happy, listen!" Peter said excitedly as he ran across rooftops. "Something big just happened! These guys were robbing an ATM, and they had these crazy weapons, and—"

Happy cut him off. "Peter, I don't have time for an ATM robbery, or thoughtful notes you leave behind. I've got moving day to worry about, everything out of here by next week. We're talking super-important, high-level security stuff."

"Moving day? You're moving?"

“Don’t you watch the news? Tony sold Avengers Tower. We’re relocating to the new facility upstate, where, hopefully, the phone service is much worse.”

“But what about me?” Peter asked. He was almost back to the alley where he’d left his stuff.

“What about you?”

“I mean, what if you need me? Or if something big goes down here and—” He dropped into the alley.

“Just stay away from anything too dangerous,” Happy said. “I’m responsible for making sure you’re responsible, okay?”

“I am responsible!” Peter protested. “I—” He looked around the alley, realizing the dumpster with his backpack—and his regular clothes—was gone. “Crap.”

“That doesn’t *sound* responsible,” Happy said drily.

“I’ll call you back,” Peter said.

“Feel free not to,” Happy responded, and hung up.

Disheartened, Peter stood in the alley for a moment. He had no clothes, Happy wouldn’t listen to him, and the Avengers were moving upstate. What was he supposed to do?

After a minute, he decided the only thing he could do was go home.



Chapter 05



Peter got through his bedroom window from the back alley and crept across the ceiling, throwing his mask on his desk. He dropped down to the floor and stretched. The fight with the ATM robbers had left him a little sore. He knew he should come up with a story about how he'd been in his room all afternoon and go say hi to May, but first he had to change.

He turned toward his dresser to get some clothes...and saw Ned, holding the building set he was working on. It slipped out of his hands and hit the floor, shattering into three thousand eight hundred and however many pieces.

“Peter, what was that?” May called from the living room.

Peter and Ned looked at each other for a long moment. How did people handle this kind of thing? Peter didn't know. His secret identity wasn't secret anymore.

Eyes wide, Ned said, "You...you're the Spider-Man—from YouTube?"

"Peter?" May called again.

"Nothing, May!" he shouted back. He tapped the spider-symbol on his chest, and the suit deactivated, turning baggy so he could pull it off. "This is just a costume," he said to Ned.

"You were on the ceiling!" Ned said. His face was glowing, like it was the coolest thing he'd ever seen.

"No, I wasn't!" Peter threw the suit into his closet, and a web shooter hit the wall. *THWIP!* A web shot out, and Peter instinctively leaped to dodge it. He ended up clinging to the ceiling, with Ned staring up at him. He dropped back down.

"Why are you in here?"

"May let me in. We were gonna finish this...." Ned said, gesturing to the pieces strewn across the floor.

At that moment, May walked into Peter's room. She wore an apron covered with food stains. "Well, that recipe didn't work," she said....And then she noticed Ned sitting on the bed and Peter standing in his boxer shorts. There was a long pause as she took it all in. Then, playing it cool, she said, "Anyway, I thought we'd go get Thai. Ned, you in?"

“He can’t,” Peter said.

“Okay,” May said. “Maybe put on clothes.” May shut the door, and Peter started to frantically get dressed.

“She doesn’t know?” Ned asked.

There was no point pretending now. “No one does,” Peter said. “Except Mr. Stark. He made the suit. But listen, Ned—”

“You’re friends with Iron Man? Wait, are you an Avenger?”

“Not officially,” Peter said. “Yet. But soon.”

“This is incredible! I feel like I’m gonna explode!”

“You gotta keep this secret, okay?”

“Secret? Why?”

“I’m already a big enough headache for May,” Peter said.

“Can you imagine if she found out guys try to kill me every night? She’d freak!” He got serious. “She can’t know. Okay? Swear it.”

Ned looked a little surprised by Peter’s sudden intensity.

“Okay,” he said. “I swear.” Then, a few seconds later, he added, “Can I try on the suit? How does it work? Is it magnets? Oh my God, it’s magnets, isn’t it?”

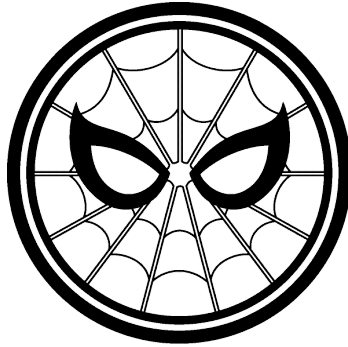
“I’ll explain everything later, all right?” Peter ushered Ned toward the door and tried to close it behind him.

“Wait,” Ned said. “How do you do all this and the Stark internship?”

Ned was a really smart guy, but sometimes he didn't see the obvious things. "Ned, there is no Stark internship."

"Ohhhhhh—"

Peter shut the door.



At the restaurant, May kept trying to get Peter to join the conversation, like she could see he had something big on his mind. "Honey, you haven't touched your larb. Too larb-y? Not larb-y enough? How many times do I have to say larb before you talk to me?"

"Sorry," Peter said. He tried to smile. "Just thinking about some internship stuff." He was also thinking about Ned and whether his friend could keep the secret. Then another part of his mind was occupied with feeling bad about the Academic Decathlon team....And that led to Liz. He liked her a lot and wanted her to like him, too.

"You sure it isn't too much?" May asked. "Life is about balance. You never have time to relax. You're always distracted."

She was definitely right. Just then, Peter was distracted because a newscaster on the restaurant TV started talking about the ATM robbery. “We’re covering a violent incident in Queens tonight,” she said over footage of police at the scene, “involving illicit alien technology left behind from the Battle of New York. According to the Department of Damage Control’s director, Ann-Marie Hoag, this is—”



May was trying to get Peter’s attention again. “*Laaaaarb ...* Peter, I larb you so much...” But he was still captivated by footage of the Battle of New York. During the fight, energy beams the same purple as the ATM robbers’ cutting tool shot in all directions. May waved her hand in front of Peter’s face.

“Peter, hey. Hello. I want to hang out.” She glanced over her shoulder and saw what was on the TV. “If you ever see something like that, you turn and you run.”

“I know, I know...” Peter said.

“I mean it. I don’t want you getting vaporized.”

This was getting uncomfortable. Peter changed the subject.

“Hey, um...I need a new backpack.”

“What? That’s, like, the fifth one!”

“I promise I won’t lose the sixth.”

“You know the straps go over your shoulders and not someone else’s, right?”

“Yeah.”

May shook her head. “Unbelievable.” But then she started to laugh. Embarrassed, but also grateful that he had May in his life, Peter laughed, too.



Chapter 06



On their way to school the next morning, Peter and Ned passed the wreckage that used to be Dalmar's. It was cordoned off with police tape, and so was the destroyed ATM booth. Cops and Damage Control agents were everywhere, including the director—Hoag, the one Peter saw on TV at the restaurant.

Ned barely noticed. He was too focused on the story Peter had just been telling him, about how he became Spider-Man. "That's how it happened? You got bit by a spider?" Peter nodded. "Can it bite me? Wait, did it hurt? Whatever—even if it hurts, I would do it. Probably. How much did it hurt?"

"Sorry, man," Peter said. "I'm pretty sure that spider's dead." He didn't want to talk about it anymore.

Finally, Ned noticed all the destruction they were passing. "Whoa. You were here? You could have died." He got serious, but it lasted for only a second, until the next weird idea floated into his head. "So, do you lay eggs?"

"What? No! And stop asking so many questions. Someone'll hear you."

"Okay," Ned said. But he didn't. In history class, he leaned over and whispered, "Can you communicate with spiders? Are tarantulas as chill as they seem?"

Peter shushed him. But walking to chemistry class, it came up again. "Do you tend to linger in high corners and under the sofa?"

“What?” Peter had no idea how to answer that question. He couldn’t even fit under a sofa.

In gym class, they sat watching a video of Captain America talking about physical fitness. “Do you know him, too?” Ned whispered.

“Quiet!” Peter whispered back. But then, because he couldn’t help himself, he added, “We’ve met.” He wanted to tell Ned about how he’d grabbed Cap’s shield in Leipzig, but he couldn’t. At least, not yet.

“Whether you’re in the gym or on the battlefield,” Cap said, “physical fitness means the difference between success and failure. Today, my friend, your gym teacher, will conduct the Captain America Physical Fitness Challenge.” Cap gestured off the screen. Coach Wilson, who was standing next to the screen and half zoning out and half waiting for his cue, stepped forward.

“Thank you, Captain America. Let’s show ’em we’re more than a math and science school.” He blew his whistle, and the class started the exercises in the challenge. Midtown didn’t really have any jocks, so Peter had to be careful not to do his sit-ups too fast. He had to fit in and do his sit-ups the way he used to before the spider bite.

Next to him, Ned said, “Hey, can I be your ‘guy in the chair’?” Peter looked over at him. He had no idea what Ned meant. “You know how there’s always a guy with a headset looking at a bunch of screens and telling the other guy where to go?”

“Ned, I don’t think—”

“Looking good, Parker!” Coach Wilson said as he passed them.

Peter realized he was doing the sit-ups too fast. He slowed down and started to grunt with fake effort.

Nearby, Betty and Liz were talking about Spider-Man. “Did you see that bank security cam on YouTube? He fought four guys.”

“She’s crushing on Spider-Man,” Betty said to another kid on the Academic Decathlon team, Seymour.

“Kind of,” Liz admitted with a dreamy smile.

Before Peter could stop him, Ned blurted out, “Peter knows Spider-Man!”

“Ned!” Peter yelled.

The girls looked at them. So did Flash and some of the other Decathlon kids. The gym got uncomfortably quiet.

“They’re...friends,” Ned explained, still unable to help himself.

Flash rolled his eyes. “Yeah, just like Captain America is friends with Coach Wilson.”

They were all looking at Peter, who felt trapped. He had to say something, and he didn’t want to make Ned look stupid. “I sort of know him through my Stark internship.” With an

angry and meaningful look at Ned, he added, "I'm not really supposed to talk about it."

"Wow, that's awesome, Parker," Flash said sarcastically. Clearly, he didn't believe either Peter or Ned. "You should bring him to Liz's party."

Peter looked over at Liz. He hadn't known about any party. "I'm having people over tonight," she said. "You're totally welcome to come."

Flash grinned. "It's gonna be lit. And you should totally invite your personal friend, Spider-Man."

Liz shot Flash a look. "It's okay. I know Peter's too busy for parties anyway."

Peter wanted to sink into the floor. He knew he'd disappointed Liz by bailing on the Washington trip. But what could he do about it? The bell rang and everyone started walking out of the gym. As soon as it was just him and Ned, Peter said, "Ned, what are you doing?!"

"Helping you out," Ned answered. He saw Peter didn't totally agree and added, "Weren't you listening? Liz has a crush on you."

Oh, Peter thought. He knew they were talking about Spider-Man, but wasn't he technically Spider-Man? Sure, Liz didn't know they were the same person....But she did have a crush on him.

Peter couldn't help smiling at the idea. "I guess I'll just ask Mr. Stark for the night off," he said.

“Right, the internship,” Ned said.

“No, remember? The internship isn’t real,” Peter said. For a smart kid, Ned was refusing to learn this part of the Spider-Man gig. “I was—never mind.”



Chapter 07



Peter and Ned made a plan to meet up later that night so May could drive them to Liz's house. Ned leaned up from the backseat and whispered so May wouldn't hear. "Just

make an appearance, slip out, and come back in as you-know-who.”

Peter was wearing the Spider-Man suit under his clothes, and thinking about the plan made him tug at his sleeve again to make sure his shirt fully covered the bright red costume.

“What are you whispering about?” May wanted to know. “A girl?”

“No, it’s not—it’s nothing,” Peter said.

May looked into the backseat, taking in Ned’s outfit and his fedora. “Ned, some hats wear men. You wear that hat.”

Ned beamed. “Yeah. It gives me confidence.”

Liz’s house was in a ritzy part of Forest Hills. As they pulled up, they could hear music from the party. “Aw, I miss these,” May said.

Ned clapped Peter on the shoulder. “It’s gonna be a night to remember.”

Peter wasn’t feeling nearly as excited. “This was a mistake,” he said. “Let’s go home.”

“Are you kidding? Go have fun.” May made a shooing gesture. When he still didn’t move, she got a mischievous expression and said, “Look, I know it isn’t easy. Trying to fit in...while your body is changing...flowering.” May grinned.

Peter rolled his eyes. She was teasing him to get him out of the car. “The urges you feel are totally natural,” she added.

“Okay, all right,” Peter said, getting out of the car before she could really embarrass him.

“Peter,” she called after him. He stuck his head back in. “Seriously. Try to have fun, okay?”

He nodded and they shared a smile. Then Peter and Ned walked up to the house and inside, feeling the thump of the bass. A DJ was somewhere inside the house, and every room was crowded with cool, older kids. Peter and Ned stayed close to the wall, not sure where to go. “Okay,” Ned said. “Just have Spider-Man swing in and say you guys are tight. And he can give me a fist bump or one of those bro half hugs.”

“This is crazy.” Peter shook his head. They were out of their league and he wanted to go home. But instead, they kept going deeper into the party until they nearly ran smack into Michelle.

“I can’t believe you guys are at this lame party,” she said.

“You are, too,” Peter pointed out.



“Am I?” she responded. Then she wandered off. Peter and Ned exchanged a look. Michelle was pretty weird sometimes.

Peter turned to see that Liz had walked up. “Hey, guys,” she said with a bright smile.

“Oh, hey, Liz,” Peter said. He was trying to act cool, but he was flustered, so he wasn’t really pulling it off. “Grice party—I mean, great party, very nice.”

“Thanks. I thought you’d be studying.”

Ah. She *was* still mad at him about the Academic Decathlon team. Peter didn’t know what to say, but thankfully Ned jumped in to save him. “Sick house! I can’t believe your parents let you have a party here!”

“Well, they feel guilty for working all the time,” she said. “So I get to throw a party, and they get an excuse to work

late again.”

“That’s cool. I mean, not that they’re always working, just the...party portion...” Peter forced out another sentence.

Again, Ned came to the rescue. “Peter’s aunt works a lot, too. So you have that in common.”

“Yeah,” Peter said. “That is a common... ality.”

Liz glanced over at her friends, then back at Peter. “Cool,” she said, clearly feeling the awkwardness of the situation. “Well, have fun.”

She headed off to rejoin her friends. “Dude, what are you waiting for?” Ned asked. “She’s right there! Spider it up!”

“No way,” Peter said. “Spider-Man isn’t some party trick. I’m not doing it.”

“Hey, Parker!” Flash Thompson’s voice boomed through the DJ microphone. “Where’s your buddy, Spider-Man? Let me guess, fighting crime in the Niagara Falls area?”

All the cool kids laughed at Peter. He looked over at Liz, who avoided eye contact. Clearly, she was embarrassed. Peter was definitely embarrassed, too. And angry. Mostly angry. Maybe Spider-Man would put in an appearance after all, just so Peter could watch Flash Thompson shut up for once.

He left the room where Flash’s DJ equipment was set up and found his way through Liz’s house to the backyard. After checking to make sure nobody was looking, he

climbed up onto the roof and stripped off his outer layer of clothes, muttering to himself. What would he say as Spider-Man? That he was just swinging by? No, that was stupid. The whole plan was stupid.

He started putting his clothes back on. Then he heard a boom in the distance. He saw a burst of purple energy. Just like the blast at the ATM booth.

Peter put on his Spider-Man mask. The suit activated, and the lens display pinpointed the location of the energy blast. It was near an old bridge about a mile away.

He could get there in no time at all.





Chapter 08



Hanging from the side of the bridge span, Spider-Man looked down as another burst of purple energy blew up an abandoned car. The whole area was abandoned buildings and scrapyards. Three men stood at the edge of one of the outcroppings. One of them, with a shaved head and a beard, held a weapon that looked like it was made from a piece of an Ultron drone—the same drones that the Avengers had defeated an army of in Sokovia. His pal looked nervous. They were clearly trying to sell some weapons to the third guy. Near them was a van with its back doors open. Inside were crates full of weapons and unidentifiable gadgets.

“Direct from Sokovia,” the bearded guy said to the third guy, their client.

“I said stop shooting that thing,” the other guy said. “What’s the matter with you?”

“Look, man,” their prospective client said, shaking his head. “I need money. My plan is to rob people, not send them back in time or whatever.”

Peter’s phone rang. He jumped, nearly falling off the bridge, and scrambled to mute it, but it was too late.

“What’s that?” the bearded guy said, looking up and pointing his gun as he searched for the source of the ringtone.

Before he could shoot, Spider-Man leaped down and webbed the gun to his hand, fouling the barrel. “Uh,

you're...under arrest!" he said, trying to sound authoritative.

The bearded guy's partner spun toward the client and drew some sort of alien-hybrid gun, gleaming and scary. "You set us up!"

The client backed up a few steps, hands in the air, clearly terrified.

"Hey!" Spider-Man shouted. "If you gotta shoot at somebody, shoot at me."

The client looked at Spider-Man, astonished. But the guy with the gun just shrugged. "Okay," he said, and fired.

Spider-Man dodged. "Nice try," he said.

Then the other guy hit him as hard as he'd ever been hit. Spider-Man reeled back, crashing into the embankment by the bridge. In his free hand, the bearded guy had some kind of big metal gauntlet that glowed with a crazy energy.

The two gun dealers jumped into their van. "Who was that?" one of them said. The would-be client sprinted to his car and peeled off in the opposite direction.

Spider-Man staggered to his feet and said, "I'm...ow...Spider-Man."

As he recovered, he saw what was happening. He couldn't let them escape! He shot out a web to each vehicle, sticking to the van's back door and the car's rear window. For a moment he hung suspended in the air as the webs drew

taut—and then the car’s back window popped out. Spider-Man hit the ground and skidded along as the van roared away into the neighborhood near the bridge.



Thanks to his suit’s enhanced sensors, he could just barely hear the two guys in the van yelling at each other. “I told you not to blow up that car,” one of them said. “We gotta call him.”

“No,” the bearded guy said. He was watching out the open back door as Spider-Man pulled himself up the web toward the van. “We got this.”

He grabbed a nasty-looking weapon from behind the seat and fired at Spider-Man. The blast missed, but it also blasted a huge piece out of the van’s back end. The van fishtailed, and the bearded guy dropped the gun. It bounced out of the back of the van and past Spider-Man, landing in the brush at the side of the road.

“I’m calling him,” the other guy said. He jerked the wheel to one side, trying to make a turn, and Spider-Man was flung off. He hit a gazebo in the yard of a house and lost his grip on the web. By the time he somersaulted to his feet, the van was too far away to web again. He was back in a leafy, suburban part of Forest Hills, and all he could do was dash madly through backyards and hope he caught the van before it got to one of the main roads.

He sprinted past dogs, jumped over fences, and frightened little kids out in their yard in a tent. “I’m so sorry!” he called back as he kept going, using a trampoline to bounce over one last fence...and onto a golf course. With nothing to swing from, Peter had to sprint, cutting across to the houses beyond the fairway. Not the most elegant solution, but it was all he had.

Ned was calling him, but he was too busy to answer. This was bigger than whatever might be happening at Liz’s party.

He vaulted a fence and swung up onto a house just as the van screeched around the corner onto the road on the other side.

“So, thought you got away from me, did you?” Peter said, timing a jump from the house. He soared over the road as the van roared toward him, aiming a web shooter at the center of its roof. He saw the two men in the van staring at him in amazement—and then something snatched him out of the air.



Peter yelped in surprise and tried to get a look at whoever—or whatever—had grabbed him. He saw wings and a mask with glowing green eyes. Sharp talons dug painfully into his back and arms. He struggled but couldn't get free as the winged monster flew higher and higher and the lights of Queens grew smaller and smaller.

As he thrashed in the creature's grip, the spider-symbol on his suit started to flash and beep. Not knowing what else to do, Peter touched it. A parachute billowed out from the back of the suit. A split second later it caught the wind and ripped Peter out of the monster's talons. He made a mental note to thank Tony Stark for including the parachute in the suit's features, but his relief didn't last long. As he tumbled in the air, he got tangled in the chute. Instead of carrying him gently to the ground, it rippled around him as he fell. One of the last things he saw as the parachute covered his

face was the complete figure of the monster, wings spread against the moonlit sky.

He fell, desperately trying to fight his way out of the chute before he hit the ground. But he didn't make it, and he hit the surface of a lake with a huge splash. Now his panic at dying from the fall was replaced with panic at drowning before he could get out of the chute. He fought against the tangle of fabric, not sure which way was up, breath burning in his lungs....He started to pass out.

Then there was a brilliant light.

At first, Peter thought it was the white light people talk about seeing during their near-death experiences. Then someone grabbed him and pulled him up. After what seemed like ages, when they broke the surface, Peter heard Tony Stark say, "Now I know why you never went out for the diving team."





Chapter 09



Peter sat shivering on a jungle gym at the edge of a playground near the lakeshore. Iron Man hovered nearby, listening as Peter told the story. “And then this flying guy

grabbed me—he looked like a monster!” He caught himself, not wanting to seem scared in front of Iron Man. “I mean, I wasn’t scared. I knew he wasn’t a monster.”

A thought occurred to him. He was out in the middle of Queens, and Iron Man just happened to be in the neighborhood? “Wait,” Peter said. “How’d you even find me? Did you put a tracker in my suit?”

“I put *everything* in your suit,” Iron Man said. “Including this heater.”

Iron Man didn’t move, but Peter felt the suit warm up. Steam rose into the night air as he sighed. “*Oooh*, that’s good. I was fine, by the way. You didn’t have to come all the way out here—”

“Oh, I’m not there,” Iron Man said. His visor opened and Peter saw the suit of armor that had saved his life was empty.

Eight thousand miles away, Tony Stark took a drink from a passing waiter and strolled across the grounds of a Hindu temple, where he was attending a wedding. “You’re lucky this place has Wi-Fi or you’d be dead right now.” Through augmented-reality lenses in his glasses, Tony watched Peter via the Iron Man armor’s video feed.

“I had a strategy,” Peter protested.

“What, to die and fight him in the afterlife?”

“That guy’s the source of those weapons. I gotta take him down!”

“Take him down?” Tony echoed. “Easy, Crockett. Stay out of it. There are people who handle this sort of thing.”

“Who, the Avengers?”

“Uh, no. This is a little below their pay grade, but trust me. Just drop it.”

“Why?” Peter whined.

Tony didn’t have much experience with teenagers, and in general didn’t have much patience for people arguing with him. “Because I said so!” he snapped. Then he added, “Sorry” to the crowd as he saw people turning to look at him.

“It’s okay,” Peter said, “but—”

“Not you. Look, forget the flying guy.”

Confused, Peter asked, “Are you talking to me now?”

“Yes,” Tony said, trying to keep the frustration out of his voice. “Just—stay closer to the ground, in Queens...build up your game helping the little people. Like that old lady who bought you the churro.”

Peter winced. Why did he have to mention the churro? “But I’m ready for more!”

“No,” Tony said firmly. “You’re not.”

Now Peter was getting frustrated. “That’s not what you thought when I took on Captain America.”

“Kid, if Cap had wanted to lay you out, he would’ve. Believe me.” Tony paused, not wanting Peter to feel bad about himself. “Look,” he went on in a calmer tone. “Just keep it local. Try to be, you know, a...friendly neighborhood Spider-Man.”

“For how much longer?” Peter wanted to know. “Don’t say after high school.”

“How about nobody says anything? Ten seconds, no talking: go.” Peter waited. Tony stood in the middle of the wedding festivities, watching people go by and thinking the situation over. Then he walked toward his car.

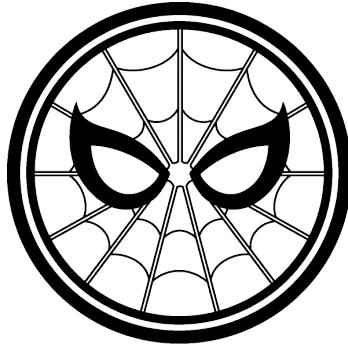
Back in the park, still sitting on the jungle gym, Peter waited until he’d counted to ten. Then he asked, “Are you still there?” He heard the sound of a car starting. “Wait, are you driving?”

“How about after college?” Tony suggested. “Have you thought about where you want to go?”

“College?!” Peter shouted. “But I—”

“Mr. Stark is no longer connected,” the Iron Man suit said. Its visor closed and the suit jetted away into the sky, leaving Peter alone.

Friendly neighborhood Spider-Man, huh? Peter had his sights set a little higher than that. No matter what Tony Stark said, he was going to find out who the guy in the wing suit was. And he was going to stop him. That would prove he was ready to be an Avenger.



The first thing he did was search along the road for the weapon he'd seen fall out of the van. It took a while, but eventually he found it, broken into several pieces. One of them was a housing for a weird glowing, purple...crystal? Stone? It was hard to tell. But it was definitely not ordinary. Chitauri? Ultron? Or something else? Peter grinned, imagining how he was going to unlock its secrets.

His phone rang. It was Ned. Peter answered. "Ned, don't worry. I'm coming back to the party."

"Yeah, I was calling to say maybe you shouldn't," Ned said. "Flash has the whole party doing a chant about you."

Peter could hear the chant in the background, over the music. It was an incredibly unfortunate pun on his name, and everyone there seemed to be shouting it loudly and happily.

Ned said something else, but Peter wasn't paying attention anymore. That was just the perfect end to this night.



Chapter 10



In the warehouse they'd been using for the last eight years, Adrian Toomes's crew worked putting together weapons. The lead tech was Mason, now known as the Tinkerer to the other guys. His worktable was littered with bits of Chitauri tech, pieces of Ultron drones, even some gear holding Dark Elf magic and found Hydra components.

A bank of dusty computer monitors against the brick wall displayed highway maps, tracking the other guys' locations—except one, which was tuned to a baseball game. Mason listened to chatter over different radio frequencies while he put the finishing touches on a new weapon powered by shards of some kind of magic metal from a Dark Elf dagger. He reached for a tool to attach the last piece, but it wasn't where he thought he'd left it. Looking around, he remembered. It was on the other side of the wall, at another workbench.

He picked up a small device he'd just finished and stuck it on the wall next to the monitors. A section of the wall became transparent, glimmering a rich purple. The device phased matter. Mason had built several of them. They weren't as exciting as weapons to most people, but he thought the phasing tech was even cooler. He reached through the wall and got the tool from the bench on the other side. Then he removed the device, and the wall was solid again.

Right then, Toomes swooped into the warehouse through the open loading doors and braked to a halt with the suit's enormous wings. He raised his arms, and the wings automatically disengaged from the rest of the suit, locking

themselves into a hanging frame. Then he took off his helmet. As soon as he was clear, he shouted, flinging the helmet across the room.

Mason had tracked some of what was going on, but he hadn't really paid attention to the details. "You okay?" he asked.

"Idiots," Toomes growled.

After a pause, Mason said, "Your wife's been texting you. Something about a brake light."

Toomes glared at him. "What'd I tell you about looking at my phone?"

"It was on your desk," Mason pointed out. "I'm a curious soul—you know that."

Squealing and groaning, the van that had barely eluded Spider-Man rolled into the warehouse. Its roof and side panels were torn up, and one of its tires was flat. Brice and Schultz hopped out, looking at Toomes. "Which one of you lit up the Stark Signal?" he demanded, meaning which of them had used the weapons. Tony Stark was bound to notice that.

Schultz gave Brice a significant glance. Toomes picked up on it. "How many times have I told you not to fire 'em off in the open?"

"You said to move the merchandise," Brice argued. He was still wearing the electric gauntlet. Once Mason had

demonstrated it, Brice had claimed it for his own, and now he wore it almost all the time.

“*Below* the radar,” Toomes shot back, pointing at the gauntlet. “That’s how we survive. You bring Damage Control or the Avengers down on us, we’re done. But here you are, lighting up cars, running around with that thing, and calling yourself the Shocker? What is this, pro wrestling?”

Schultz and Mason tried not to laugh. Brice bristled at the insult. “Whatever you say, old man.”

“Hey,” Toomes said before Brice could walk past him. “I know you don’t give a crap about anything, but I do. I built all this because I got people to look after.”

Brice rolled his eyes. “Yeah, yeah, yeah...”

Toomes cocked his head to one side. He made a decision. “You know what? I can’t afford any more of your crap. You’re out.”

“What? You can’t kick me off the crew!” Brice looked to Mason and Schultz. Both were looking somewhere else.

“It’s my crew,” Toomes pointed out. “And I just did.”

The warehouse was quiet. Everyone watched to see how the confrontation would end. Brice had challenged Toomes, and now things were going to be settled one way or another.

“All right,” Brice smirked. He took a step back from Toomes. “So I guess you *can* afford me out there? With everything I know...” Brice let his words hang in the air.

“Excuse me?” Toomes understood the threat. Brice might tell anyone about the operation—especially if someone paid him. Eight years of work would go up in smoke. Toomes would be in jail, and then who would take care of his family?

Brice shrugged, still smirking. “Just saying. Maybe your wife would like to know where you really get your money from.”

After a brief pause, Toomes said, “You’re right. I can’t afford that.”

He picked up the weapon Mason had just finished and fired. A beam of dark energy struck Brice and washed over him, disintegrating him where he stood. The Shocker gauntlet fell to the floor into a small pile of dark powder, all that was left of Brice.

Shocked, Toomes looked at what he had done. Then he looked at Mason. “I thought this was the antigravity gun!”

“What?” Mason pointed at the end of the bench. “No, that’s that one.”

Toomes turned back to Brice’s remains. He couldn’t change it now. The only thing to do was move on. He picked up the Shocker gauntlet and blew the powder off it. Then he tossed

it to Schultz. “Here. Now you’re the Shocker. Clean up any messes you guys made out there.”

Everyone started to get back to work. Toomes stood, coming to terms with what he had just done. He wasn’t a killer and he hadn’t meant to kill Brice. But now the stakes of the operation were that much higher.

At a nearby worktable, one of the crew was putting a glowing purple Chitauri battery into another weapon. Shaken by what he’d just seen, he nearly dropped it. “Careful!” Toomes warned. “Those are dangerous.”

“One wrong move,” Mason added, “and...” He mimicked a big explosion with his hands.

The tech took a deep breath and got back to work.



Chapter 11



At school the next day, Peter took advantage of the workstation he had in shop class. He'd brought the glowing purple crystal in, and while the rest of his classmates

worked on picture frames—or whatever the assignment was—he started pounding on the casing with a hammer. The shop teacher looked up for a moment and made some routine comment about safety, but he never paid attention. Peter could do whatever he wanted.

The last blow of the hammer cracked open the casing. Inside, the purple crystal was nestled in a tangle of wires and microchips. Peter tried to pry it out but couldn't at first. He paused to think about what to do next. Ned came up to him and said, "Whoa. What is that?"

"I don't know," Peter said without looking up. "Some guy tried to vaporize me with it."

"Seriously? Awesome." Now Peter did look up, and Ned backtracked. "I mean, not awesome, obviously, totally uncool of that guy..."

"I think this is its energy source. It looks alien, maybe Chitauri."



“Yeah.” Ned took a closer peek at the housing. “But it’s attached to microprocessors, and look, that’s a solid-state relay like I use for internal computer fans.”

“Someone built this weapon combining alien tech with ours.”

Ned paused. Then he said, “That is literally the coolest sentence anyone has ever said.”

Peter tried again to pry the energy source loose. This time he put a little of his spider-strength into it, and it popped out with a pulse of purple energy. He and Ned looked around to see if anyone had noticed, but everyone was looking at either projects or their phone screens. The teacher was oblivious.

“I gotta figure out what this thing is and who made it,” Peter said.

“Let’s take it to the lab after school and run some tests,” Ned suggested.

Peter nodded. “Nice.” He and Ned went through their personal handshake, a complicated series of taps and bumps they’d come up with in middle school.

Then he had to get back to the ordinary school day. When the bell rang, Peter looked for Ned and found him in the library with the rest of the Decathlon team. Liz was leading them in some practice questions, with the team coach, Mr. Harrington, looking on.

“Guys,” she was saying, “I know it’s nationals, but we have to treat DC like any other competition.” She was trying to keep them from getting too tense and missing easy questions.

Peter tapped at the library window. He caught Ned’s eye. As Ned got up to leave, Liz shot Peter an annoyed and disappointed look. He felt bad about it—he still wanted to impress her more than anything—but this was more important even than nationals.

“First, I say we put that glowy thing in the mass spectrometer,” Ned said as they headed for the physics lab.

“Before that, let’s come up with a better name than ‘glowy thing.’”

They went around the corner, and Peter stopped dead. Two men were in the hallway in front of the shop. One of them held a device out in front of him, like he was homing in on

a signal. The other was the guy who had been driving the van the night before.

“Crap,” he said, and pulled Ned back around the corner. “That’s one of the guys who tried to kill me.”

“What?” Ned looked scared. “We should leave. Possibly the state, but definitely this hallway.” He turned to go, but Peter didn’t go with him. He watched as the two men went into the shop classroom. Through the window, Peter saw them zero in on the table where he’d been pounding on the purple crystal.

“Wait,” he said. “They can lead me to the guy who dropped me in the lake.”

“Someone dropped you in a lake?” Ned asked, but Peter was already moving cautiously toward the shop. He dropped to a crawl and got into the room without their noticing. They were focused on the table.

“Says it was the right kind of energy pulse,” one of them said, looking at the scanner.

“Whatever it was, it’s gone,” the other guy said.

“So are we,” the first one said. As they walked out of the room, they passed by Peter, who hung from the underside of a table.

Aiming low, he fired a Spidey tracker from one of his web shooters. It landed on one of their boots and scuttled into a seam. As long as the guy didn’t get a new pair of boots, Peter would now know everywhere he went.

The two men left, and Peter dropped down from the underside of the table. He'd forgotten all about any experiments he wanted to run in the physics lab. When he got back to Ned, the two of them went straight to Peter's apartment.



Chapter 12



Once they were in Peter's room, Peter showed Ned one of the coolest things he'd learned his suit could do. Not only could the web shooters launch trackers, but they also could project a holographic map that showed the tracker's location in real time. Peter and Ned sat and watched the tracker go: Brooklyn...Staten Island...Jersey...

"They stopped," Peter said.

Ned looked up. "Latham, Maryland? What's there?"

"Could be their evil lair."

"They have a *lair* ?"

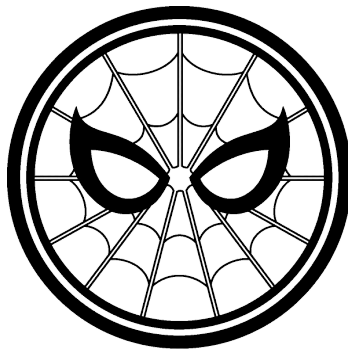
“A gang with alien weapons, run by a guy with wings?” Peter nodded. “They have a lair.” Peter’s attention was locked on the hologram. “I’ve gotta go check it out.”

“But it’s, like, three hundred miles away,” Ned pointed out. “How are you gonna get there?”

Peter thought about this. Looking around his room, he noticed the poster for the Academic Decathlon nationals, starting tomorrow in Washington, DC. That gave him an idea....

“It’s not that far from DC,” he said.

This time Ned understood right away. “Liz is gonna kill you,” he said.



Peter got to school just as the other members of the Academic Decathlon team, in their yellow blazers, were about to board the bus. He ran up and slapped his permission slip into Mr. Harrington’s hand. Liz looked on, puzzled. “Peter?”

“Hey, buddy!” Ned shot him a big smile.

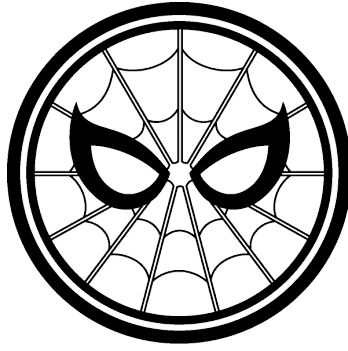
With Liz looking at him, Peter got awkward. “I was thinking maybe I could...you know...rejoin the team...?”

“But I thought—”



“No way,” Flash said, shouldering his way through the crowd. “You can’t quit on us and then just turn around and stroll up here expecting to—”

Mr. Harrington cut him off. “Welcome back, Parker,” he said, clearly delighted to have Peter back on the team. And that was that. The rest of the team filed onto the bus. Flash followed, refusing to look at Peter. Liz did look at him, but the look made him feel sheepish more than anything. She shook her head, still irritated at him....But she couldn’t help but smile, too.



They were on the outskirts of Washington, DC, with Liz still quizzing them on every topic under the sun, when Peter's phone rang. He answered.

"Got a little blip on my screen here," said Happy Hogan.
"You left New York?"

The tracker! He'd forgotten all about it. "It's just a school trip. And I gotta say, Happy, tracking me without my permission—not cool. It's a complete violation of my privacy. Is this the kind of world we want to live in?"

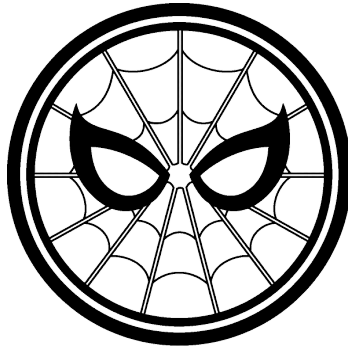
Ned gave him a look. After all, they were at that moment tracking another person without his permission. "This is different," Peter said to him.

"What's different?" Happy asked, thinking Peter was talking to him.

"Uh, nothing," Peter said. "Look, we're just going to DC for Academic Decathlon. It's no big deal."

"I'll decide if it's no big deal," Happy shot back, his voice stern. Peter got nervous. Then, after a long moment, Happy said, "It seems like no big deal. Just be careful. Someone once stole my sister's camera in DC."

“Okay, got it,” Peter said. Happy hung up. Peter immediately turned to Ned. “I need your help with something.”



In their hotel room, with a *do not disturb* sign hanging from the doorknob, Peter and Ned turned the Spider-Suit inside out, exposing a complex array of circuitry, sensor pads...all kinds of stuff Peter couldn't identify. Ned used a bunch of electrical clamps to wire the circuits into his laptop, and in a few minutes, he accessed the suit's code. He scrolled through, looking for a few command lines in particular.

Meanwhile, Peter was following different lines of circuitry, looking for the tracking device embedded in the suit. “Peter, why are we removing the tracker from your suit?” Ned asked.

Peter watched the tracking hologram. “Because I need to follow these guys to their boss before they move again. And I don't want Mr. Stark to know.”

“So we're lying to Iron Man?”

“We're not lying. He just doesn't get what I can do yet.” He spotted the tiny chip he'd been looking for. “Got it.” Carefully, he peeled the tracker loose and held it up. Then

he looked around the room. “Have fun tracking this lamp,” he said to an imaginary Happy Hogan, sticking the tracker to the inside of the lamp shade.



“Whoa,” Ned said, still poking around in the suit’s code. “There’s a ton of other subsystems in here. But they’re disabled by the...” He trailed off.

Peter looked at the laptop screen and saw what Ned had seen. “Training Wheels Protocol?” That was just insulting. “Can you turn it off?”

“Yeah, but I don’t think it’s a good idea,” Ned cautioned. “These features are probably blocked for a reason.”

“I don’t need training wheels. I’m sick of him treating me like a kid.”

“You are a kid,” Ned said.

“Yeah, a kid who can stop a bus with his bare hands!” Peter yelled. Ned still seemed uncertain. Looking at his friend, Peter calmed himself down. “I can handle it, Ned. Come on, this is my chance to prove myself. Please?”

Ned sighed and typed a series of commands. A new message appeared on the screen: *PROTOCOL DISABLED* . At the same time, the suit twitched. They looked at it for a nervous moment. “When I put it on, I’m not going to explode or anything, am I?” Peter asked.

Ned didn’t answer. So Peter put the suit on. He didn’t explode.

Okay , he thought. Time to go get the bad guys.



Chapter 13



He slipped out of the room, wearing the Spider-Suit under his regular clothes. Then he remembered something and turned in the doorway. “The glowy thing? It’s evidence. Keep it safe.”

“Keep yourself safe,” Ned answered.

The tracker hologram projected from the suit’s wristband, and Peter watched it as he sneaked down the hallway. A glass wall across from the rooms looked down on the hotel pool, closed for the night. He was so preoccupied with the signal that he didn’t notice Liz in the hall until she said, “Come on! We’re going swimming!”

Peter spun around, hiding the hologram down by his side. The rest of the Decathlon team, wearing bathing suits and carrying towels, ran by, heading for the pool.

“I can’t,” he said. “I gotta...go study. In the business center.”

“Peter, you don’t need to study. You’re, like, the smartest guy I ever met. And besides, a rebellious group activity the day before competition is good for morale, and teenagers respond to things they perceive to be against the rules.” Peter was confused. How did she know all this? She saw his expression and smiled. “I heard it in a TED talk. And I read a coaching book,” Liz conceded.

Peter smiled back. “Boy...this is really important to you.”

“Yeah, it’s our future. I don’t want to screw it up. Besides, I raided the minibar, and these candy bars are, like, eleven

dollars. So get your trunks on and come on.” She trotted off after the rest of the team.

From the hotel roof, he watched them while he got out of his clothes and put on the Spider-Suit mask. He could do it. He could just be a regular kid, hanging out with his friends, maybe talking some more to this beautiful and brilliant girl he really liked....

It looked like fun, but he was Spider-Man. He had responsibilities.

When he put the mask on, he was surprised to see a holographic heads-up display on the inside of the lenses. That was new. Before, the lenses had some enhanced vision, but this was...this was like being inside Iron Man’s helmet. *Wow* , Peter thought. *I have my own HUD.*

He got another surprise when a female AI voice said, “Good evening, Peter. Congratulations on completing the rigorous Training Mode Protocol and gaining access to your suit’s full capabilities.”

Whoa , he thought. Ned had really done it. He’d hacked the suit so it thought...wow. “Hello? Thank you.”

“So where would you like to take me tonight?”

“Oh,” Peter said. “Uh, I put a tracker on someone. He’s a bad guy.” The suit scanned for it, and the spot appeared on his HUD.

“Tracker located,” the AI said. “Plotting course to intercept target.”

“Okay, well, as long as I make it back in time for the Decathlon, it’s fine.” He was running as he talked, catching a ride on a passing truck. He rode it for miles until he came to an interchange north of the city, then it—she?—directed him to hop onto another truck, headed in a different direction. That went on until, on a remote road, the AI said, “One hundred meters from target and closing, Peter. Jump now.”

Spider-Man jumped off the back of the truck and saw the target. It was an abandoned gas station. He climbed up an old sign for a long-gone restaurant near the station and watched a van parked near the pumps. He could see a guy he didn’t know at the wheel. One of the guys who had been searching the school was sitting in the passenger seat. But he couldn’t tell what they were doing.

“Detecting three individuals,” the AI said.

“Wow,” Peter said. “Is their secret lair in a gas station? That’s so lame. Hey, Suit-Lady, what are they doing?”

“Do you want to hear what they’re saying?”

“I can hear what they’re saying? Uh, yeah.”

“Activating Enhanced Reconnaissance Mode.”

On the suit’s HUD, he saw what looked like an X-ray of the van, with three figures inside. They were talking about stolen items, it sounded like. Something about a gauntlet and cleaning up the Triskelion. That was where the Helicarriers had crashed in the big fight between Captain

America and the Winter Soldier, back when Peter was in middle school.

“Whoa,” he said. “This is so cool.”

“Target inbound,” one of them said.

“Oh, they’re in the middle of a heist,” Peter said. “I could catch them all red-handed. This is awesome! Okay, I’m going to get a little closer so I can see what’s happening.”

“Would you like me to engage Enhanced Combat Mode?”

“Enhanced Combat Mode? Uh, yeah.”

“Activating Instant Kill,” she said.

“No, no, no! I don’t want to kill anyone.”

Peter shot a web and leaped from the top of the sign—but the web didn’t attach and he ended up crashing down onto the edge of the parking lot. “What was that?”

“You jumped off the sign and fell on your face.”

He tried to shoot again, but instead of a single line, his web shooters pumped out a series of small web pellets. “What’s wrong with my web shooters?”

“Rapid fire is the default in Enhanced Combat Mode.”

“Why would I need rapid fire?”

“Would you like to see more options? You have five hundred and seventy-six combinations.” A diagram

appeared on the HUD.

“Boy,” Peter said as he scanned his options. “Mr. Stark really overdid it.” He picked one at random.

“Great choice,” the AI said.

Peter fired the web, and a bolt of electricity ran up it and briefly shocked the dead sign into life. “What was that?!”

“Taser webs,” the AI explained.

“Why would I want Taser webs?”

“You seem to be very unfamiliar with your web shooter settings,” the AI commented. “Would you like to run a refresher course?”

“No, you choose,” Peter said.

“Sure thing,” the AI said brightly.

The guys in the van were talking about a truck again, and Peter saw three semis hauling tractor trailers coming down the road. “Visual confirmed,” one of them said. “Green light, green light.”

But how were they going to get anything off a truck when they were sitting in the van? Looking around, Peter detected a blur of motion in the night sky, and then he understood.

Descending from above and behind the truck, right where the driver couldn’t see it, was the monster in the wing suit.

He spread his wings and coasted in, glowing eyes focused on his prey.





Chapter 14



As he watched the thief glide in, just like a vulture descending on carrion, Peter knew he'd locked in on the perfect name for the "monster" that almost killed him: The

Vulture. “Oh, that’s him,” he said. He rushed to the edge of the road, waiting to time the perfect jump.

He swung behind the truck on a short length of web and clung to the back. Spider-Man peered over the edge of the roof. He saw the Vulture, wings folded, place a small device on the roof. The part of the roof below the device instantly became transparent—or not quite transparent.

Translucent, with a faint purple sheen still visible where the sheet metal of the roof had been.

The Vulture anchored his wings on the top of the container, and then he unharnessed himself from the enormous frame and dropped into the hold. Spider-Man crept close to the edge of the phased spot. He stuck his finger through it and was amazed to feel no resistance. This was cool tech, like some kind of matter phase shifter. But he had to stay focused. He looked down and saw the Vulture picking through rows of baskets containing pieces of what had to be alien tech. When he had a bagful, he turned to climb back to the roof.

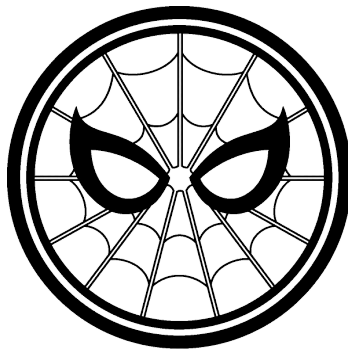
That was the time for Peter to make his move. He snapped out a web, sticking it to the Vulture’s bag of loot. As the Vulture’s masked face turned toward him, Spider-Man yelled, “Hey, Big Bird! This doesn’t belong to you!”

He snatched the Vulture’s bag away, but the Vulture reacted faster than Spider-Man was expecting. He racked his wings and slashed one of them in Peter’s direction. Peter ducked and fired webs—but they split midflight and flew past him on both sides, missing the mark completely. “Suit-Lady, what was that?”

“You told me to choose.”

“Well, just...set everything back to normal!”

“Activating default modes,” the AI said calmly—just as the Vulture swept back toward Spider-Man. One of his wings clotheslined Spider-Man across the upper part of his chest, slamming him down. Spider-Man landed on the edge of the phased area and fell into the container. As he slid in, his leg knocked the phasing device loose. He jumped back toward the ceiling as soon as he landed, but the phasing equipment was in the trailer with him, so he hit the ceiling headfirst, and then hit the back of his head on the steel floor, and after that he didn’t remember anything for a while.



He came to in darkness and silence. Groaning, Peter sat up.

“Oh, my head.”

“You appear to have a mild concussion,” the suit AI said. Peter collected himself and remembered how he’d gotten inside the container. Looking up, he saw the ceiling was a solid sheet of metal again. “Hey, so where am I right now?”

“I’m not sure,” the suit AI said. “The container walls are hindering my sensors.”

“They must have hijacked the truck and taken me to their evil lair,” Peter said. “Okay, Suit-Lady, we’re going to have to fight our way out of this one.”

He charged the container’s doors and burst through them with an echoing boom, then landed on a concrete floor ready to fight.

But he was alone. The container he’d ridden in was one of hundreds, maybe thousands, stacked in rows that receded into the darkness. This was the biggest warehouse he’d ever seen, and the only lights were dim emergency bulbs set in the ceiling and near bay doors.

“What is this place? Suit-Lady, where am I?”

“You’re in the most secure facility on the Eastern Seaboard: the Damage Control deep-storage vault.” As she spoke, Peter saw an official seal: department of damage control.

Peter started to panic. “Damage Control? No, no, no, I can’t be here! Mr. Stark will kill me!”

He walked up to a sealed blast door and pushed on it. He tried to get his fingers into the small crack in the center of the door to pull the two halves apart. They didn’t move.

“The door will likely remain closed until morning,” the suit AI commented.



“Now what am I supposed to do?” If she was right, the only way Peter was getting out was to wait until Damage Control showed up for work in the morning. If people even came out to this warehouse every day. All of a sudden he had a lot of time to kill.

He thought about Liz, and that made him feel bad all over again about running out on the Decathlon team. Especially now that he probably wasn’t going to get back to DC in time for nationals. His mind started to wander. “I feel bad calling you ‘Suit-Lady,’” he said to the AI. “I think I should probably give you a name. Like Liz. No, that’s weird. How about... Karen?”

“You can call me Karen if you’d like,” she said.

“Hey, Karen. What else can this suit do?” he asked.

Some sort of webbed glider wings popped out, connected to the suit along his ribs and under his arms. *Wow*, he

thought. Then she ran him through the rest of what the suit could do. Web grenades, ricochet webs, all kinds of stuff.

Once he'd gotten through the informal tutorial, he was cold. He pulled his Decathlon blazer out of his backpack and put it on. Time stretched out and his mind wandered back to Liz. Now that he'd given the suit AI a name, it was easier to talk to her like a person...which naturally led him to start talking about things that really mattered. "Do you think I should tell Liz that I'm Spider-Man?"

"Who is Liz?" Karen asked.

"She's the best. She's awesome. I mean, she's just a girl who goes to my school. And yeah, I want to tell her, but is it kind of weird to just be like, 'Hey, I'm Spider-Man'?"

"What's weird about that?"

"What if she's expecting someone like Tony Stark? I mean, imagine how disappointed she'd be when she sees me?"

"Well, if I were her, I wouldn't be disappointed at all," Karen said.

"Thanks, Karen. It's really nice to have somebody to talk to." Peter sighed. "So how long have we been in here?"

"Thirty-seven minutes."

"What?!" Peter leaped up. "I can't take this anymore. I gotta get out of here." He grabbed the Vulture's bag and started sorting through it. "There's gotta be something in here I can use."

He dug around, discarding pieces of weapons, an Ultron drone head....“Hey,” Peter said when he spotted one of the purple crystals. “It’s like the glowy thing.”

“That glowy thing is an explosive Chitauri energy core,” Karen explained.

“Whoa, you mean we’ve been carrying around a bomb?” Peter thought of Ned and tried to call him, but his phone had no signal.

“It would require radiation to transform it into its explosive state,” Karen said as Peter tried Ned one more time, just in case.

Peter ran to the door and looked frantically for some kind of way out. He saw a control panel, high off the ground at the edge of the door, and got an idea. If the doors were controlled by a security panel, that meant there would be a code.

And who better to hack a code than a Stark-designed AI?

He still had some of the clamps and wires in his backpack from when Ned had hacked the Spider-Suit. “Karen, you have to help me override that time lock.”

Peter scrambled to his backpack and dragged out a fistful of the wires and clamps. He clung to the wall and wired the suit into an access panel. After that, Karen could start prying into the security system, looking for the code that would open the door. It was just a matter of time.

He hoped he had enough.



Chapter 15



By the time Karen cracked the code and they got out of the Damage Control vault, it was morning. Peter caught a ride on a Damage Control truck headed away from the storage complex and tried to call Ned, but Ned wasn't answering his phone. Peter left messages constantly while he hopped onto different trucks, making his way back toward Washington, DC. Finally, hours later, Ned answered.

"Peter! Are you okay?"

"Ned! Where's the glowy thing?"

"Don't worry, it's safe. I got it in my backpack."

"What?"

"Dude, you missed the Decathlon."

"I did?" Peter looked at his phone and registered what time it was. *Oh no*, he thought.

"You did. Yeah, we're at the Washington Monument now," Ned said.

Worse and worse. Not only did Ned have a bomb, but he had a bomb at the Washington Monument. Where there would be security. Security that used X-rays. Would the X-rays do something to the glowy thing? "Ned, listen! You have to—"

He heard a brief scuffling noise and then Liz's voice. "Peter, is that you?"

"Liz?"

“You flake!” That was about the strongest language she ever used. *She must be really mad at me* , Peter thought. “You’re lucky we won anyway or I would—”

How could he explain? “Liz—”

“I want to be mad, but I’m also worried. I mean, what is going on with you? Level with me.”

“What? Liz, listen to me!”

In the background he heard someone talking to Liz. “Miss, all items on the belt.”

Belt , Peter thought. *Security conveyor belt. X-ray screening.*

“Peter, I gotta go, but you’re in big trouble,” she said, and hung up.

“Liz! Liz!” Frantically, Peter redialed Ned. No answer.

Peter looked around. The truck was on a bridge over the Potomac, heading right into downtown DC. “Karen,” he said, jumping off as the truck headed for an underpass, “show me the way to the Washington Monument!”

He caught a ride on a tour bus headed for the National Mall....But it stopped at the wrong place on the National Mall, all the way down by the Lincoln Memorial. Jumping off, he started the long sprint toward the Washington Monument. “How long is this thing?” He panted as he ran along the reflecting pool.

“The Lincoln Memorial Reflecting Pool is two thousand and twenty—”

“I wasn’t really asking!” As he ran, he webbed his backpack to a tree. The Washington Monument was on a low hill, and Peter dashed up to the plaza around the monument’s base, almost running straight into Michelle. Again. She probably had refused to do the tour for a contrary political protest—classic Michelle move.

He ran up to her and tried to disguise his voice, making it deeper. “Where’s your class?”

Michelle looked up and saw who was asking. Talking to Spider-Man was apparently enough to shake even her normally invincible cool. She blinked and stumbled over whatever she’d been about to say. “Uhh...” She pointed straight up.



Peter followed her finger. *That thing definitely looks taller when you see it from here*, he thought.

A moment later, a cone-shaped blast of purple energy tore through the top of the monument, flaring up into the sky and fading away. People all over the plaza screamed and pointed. “Karen! What happened? Are they okay?!”

“Engaging sonar hyperthermal analysis,” Karen said calmly. The Spider-Suit’s lenses showed a wireframe overlay of the monument’s structure, all the way up to the elevator. It was nearly to the top. The wireframe also showed where the Chitauri energy blast had cut through the monument and the elevator. “All elevator occupants appear to be alive—”

“Thank God,” Peter breathed.

“For the next eight minutes and twenty seconds,” Karen went on. “The elevator’s structural integrity has been compromised and it will fall.”

“What are you doing?” Michelle shouted from right next to him. “Help them!”

“Yeah, yeah, on it!” Spider-Man said, forgetting to disguise his voice. As he ran toward the monument and leaped to begin the climb up its side, he wondered if Michelle had noticed. If she had recognized his voice...

Never mind, he told himself. It was a long climb to the top of the Washington Monument. He had eight minutes. Thanks to the hyperthermal analysis, he could see on his HUD people trying to get off the elevator. That was good. The park rangers would help. But Peter still had to get up there....

“The safety systems are completely failing,” Karen said.
“The occupants are in imminent mortal danger. They will fall in seven minutes and twelve seconds.”

“Not if I get there first,” Spider-Man said. He climbed faster.

A vibration shivered through the monument’s walls. Peter felt it in his fingertips and the balls of his feet. “You now have two minutes, fifteen seconds,” Karen said.

“What?!”

“The structural deterioration has accelerated.”

He was getting closer to the top, but it occurred to him he had no idea what to do when he got there. “I gotta get in there! How do I get in there?”

The spider-symbol on his chest disengaged from the suit and took flight. “Deploying reconnaissance drone. Searching for an entry point.”

Whoa , Peter thought. His HUD switched to the drone’s POV, buzzing around the monument, accentuating how high and vulnerable he was.

“Oh my God...” he said as he saw the world through the drone’s perspective. The sudden change in the view disoriented him for a few critical seconds, and he almost started climbing down again.

But then Karen said, “Eight observation windows have been located.”

“Okay, shut it off!” He could see again. He was almost there.

“The roof will not hold for much longer,” Karen said, reminding Peter of the elevator’s status as he climbed over the ledge outside one of the observation windows. “One minute, fifteen seconds.”

Peter started kicking the window, leaning out as far as he could to get more leverage. But he couldn’t break the reinforced glass.

Behind him, a police helicopter came close enough that its rotor wash nearly knocked him off the ledge. “Return to the ground immediately!” a cop said through a megaphone. In the chopper, Peter saw a sniper, with Spider-Man squarely in his crosshairs.

“I’m trying to help them! They’re about to die!”

“Return to the ground or we will open fire!”

“Fifteen seconds,” Karen said.

The cop put the megaphone to his mouth again. “This is your last chance!”



Spider-Man had a desperate idea. He scrambled toward the beveled top of the monument, moving as fast as he could. The police helicopter rose after him. When he got to the top, he spread his arms and leaped backward, deploying the suit's web gliders and soaring out...just barely over the thumping rotors. Then he twisted his body and tucked into a fall as he webbed one of the copter's skids. Using the skid, he swung toward the observation window, gathering as much speed as he could and hoping it would be enough.



Chapter 16



Spider-Man hit the reinforced observation window feetfirst, smashing through at the same instant the roof of the elevator inside tore loose. He slid across the floor, shooting

a web down into the shaft and catching the elevator car just as his feet slammed into the half-opened elevator shaft doors. Bracing his legs and groaning with the effort, he started to pull the elevator back up, hand over hand. Around him, his classmates and the park rangers watched in astonishment. But people were still inside the elevator.

He had the elevator almost up to the observation deck again when the elevator doors he was bracing himself against gave way and he plunged into the shaft. He caromed off the shaft walls and down after the plummeting cab. It was grinding off its guide rails, and that let him catch up. Making a final leap from the wall of the shaft, he dove into the elevator and landed hard on the floor. Ned, Liz, Flash, and Mr. Harrington stared down at him in shock.

“Hey,” Ned said.

Spider-Man nodded. “Hey.”

The elevator suddenly lurched and went into free fall again. Spider-Man leaped up and shot a web to catch the gears and winch at the top of the shaft. Hanging upside down and bracing his feet on the remains of the elevator’s roof, he stopped it from falling...and then, slowly, started pulling it back up the shaft. Straining with the effort, he eventually got the elevator back to the observation deck. But he could feel the roof starting to give. It wasn’t going to hold much longer.

Flash had already scrambled to safety—he was the first person off the elevator. Ned and Mr. Harrington clambered

through the half-open doors. “Liz, come on!” Mr. Harrington called, reaching back toward her.

She was too scared to move. Spider-Man reached for her, taking the strand of web holding the whole weight of the elevator in his other hand. “Take my hand!”

The roof finally gave, and the elevator fell. “Liz!” Spider-Man screamed. She lunged for his hand but missed. He caught the web strand with his feet and shot a web down the shaft into the falling elevator, webbing her outstretched hand.

Below her, the elevator fell away into the darkness of the shaft. A long moment later, the booming sound of its impact echoed back up.

Spider-Man, still upside down, pulled Liz up and swung her to the observation deck. She and the others stared at him in shock.

“All right, is everyone okay?” he asked, putting on a fake accent. Stunned, Liz could only nod.



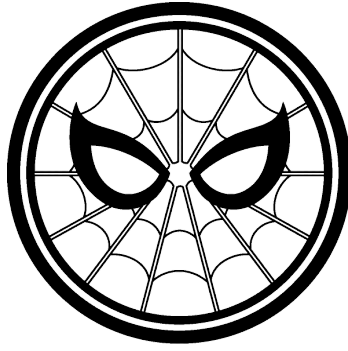
“This is your chance, Peter,” Karen said. “Kiss her.”

He might have. Maybe he should have. But at that moment, the gears where he had attached his web fell apart, and Spider-Man fell down the shaft into darkness.

Mr. Harrington called out, “Thank you.”

A moment later, Flash—clutching the Decathlon trophy—also called out. “Are you really friends with Peter Parker?” he shouted.

There was no answer.



In the warehouse, Toomes stewed while his men worked. Schultz practiced with the Shocker gauntlet, getting to know its weight and how it worked.

Mason tinkered with a new weapon. “I can finish the next order, but without any new materials from that truck...” He didn’t need to say any more. Without new material, Toomes knew they were sunk.

“We still have enough to do the Gargan deal, though, right?” Toomes asked.

Mason nodded. “And then that’s it. Maybe it’s time I built the high-altitude seal.”

“Will you shut up about that?”

“One job,” Mason said.

“No.” Toomes sat staring into space. “Eight years. Not a word from the feds, nothing from those Halloween costume-wearing bozos up in Stark Tower. And then all of a sudden, this little man in red tights shows up, and he thinks he can tear down everything I built? The second I find him...”

“Found him,” Schultz said.

On one of the monitors was news footage of the Washington Monument...and Spider-Man climbing on it. The news anchor talked about Spider-Man swooping in to save the lives of a New York City Academic Decathlon team.

Toomes watched the report. The more he watched, the more he understood. A Chitauri core had gone off in the Washington Monument. And that meant Spider-Man couldn't have been there by accident. No way he spent all his time in New York and then just happened to be in DC when those kids set off a Chitauri battery, which must have come from the weapon Brice had lost...in a fight with Spider-Man. Toomes hadn't gone to college, but he could put two and two together. Spider-Man knew one of the Academic Decathlon kids.

It wouldn't take long to figure out which one.



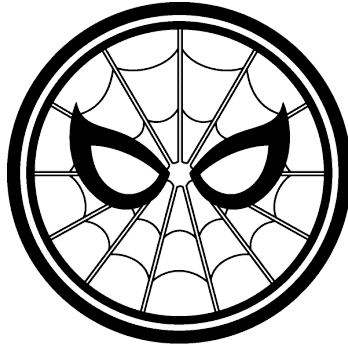
Chapter 17



On Monday, all anyone could talk about at Midtown School of Science & Technology was the Decathlon team's brush with death. The school news broadcast had interviews with most of the team members, but Peter hadn't talked to them. And he hadn't joined the crowd when the kids got off the bus the day before, because he didn't want anyone pointing out that he hadn't been there for the competition. He felt exposed, like his secret was in danger. And on top of that, he felt terrible about letting down the team. Sure, he'd been trying to stop a gang of dangerous criminals from stealing alien technology, but all the same, he'd talked his way back onto the Decathlon team and then bailed on them.

May had been in tears when she saw him get off the bus. Peter wished he could tell her more about what had happened, but he couldn't. He couldn't tell anyone. Being Spider-Man was starting to feel like a burden. It was a responsibility he wasn't sure he could handle anymore. Lucky for him, May saw that Michelle didn't have a ride home. Dropping off Michelle distracted May enough that she didn't ask Peter too many questions. He just wanted to go to his room and sit by himself, and she, thankfully, let him.

But the more he thought about it, the more he started to change his mind. The Vulture had nearly gotten a bunch of people killed by letting that alien tech out into the world. He'd nearly gotten Peter's friends killed. It was more important than ever for Peter to stop him.



The next day, the bell was ringing for first period by the time Ned found Peter in the hall. “Dude. What is it like being famous when nobody knows it’s you?”

“Crazy,” Peter admitted with a grin.

“Should we tell everyone? Should I tell everyone?”

“No,” Peter said firmly.

“Okay,” Ned said. “Let’s get to class.”

“I’m not going to class,” Peter said.

“But you’re already in so much trouble for ditching the Decathlon,” Ned warned.

“Listen, I figured it out. The wing-suit guy, he’s stealing from Damage Control. And what he takes from Damage Control, that’s how he makes the weapons. All I have to do is catch him.”

“But we have a Spanish quiz,” Ned protested.

“Ned, I’m probably never going to come back here. Mr. Stark is moving the Avengers upstate, so when I bring

this guy in..."

Ned looked shocked. "You want to be a high school dropout?"

Peter rolled his eyes and started walking backward. "I am so far beyond high school right now."

Then he turned and almost ran into Principal Morita, standing in his way.

"Parker," Morita said. "My office."

Lecture time. He got the standard speech about being a good kid, a smart kid, but he needed to get his head on straight before he compromised his future. Peter listened through it all, but he really paid attention when the sentencing started: It was detention. "Get out of here," Morita said, not unkindly, and Peter headed out into the hall. Ned—good, old, supportive Ned—was waiting. Peter filled him in on the situation and then slogged his way through his classes....And when the bell rang at the end of the day, he slogged his way into the detention room.

Like every other school activity, this one had a Captain America video to go with it. Cap walked on-screen and turned a chair around backward before sitting with his legs straddling the seat and his arms folded over the backrest. "So you broke the rules, trying to be cool," he said. "Well, take it from a guy who was frozen for sixty-five years: Being 'cool' isn't all it's cracked up to be."

Peter vowed that the next time he saw Cap, he was going to mention these videos. Some things just couldn't be let go.

That thought got him moving. If he was ever going to be an Avenger, he had to see things through. Even if people didn't understand. Even if it got him in trouble at school. As he'd said to Ned that morning, he was way beyond high school.

He got up and started walking out of the classroom. "Hey," Coach Wilson said without looking up from his computer. "Where are you going?"

Peter didn't answer. He just kept walking. Behind him, he heard Coach Wilson talking to Michelle. "Why are you here? You don't even have detention."

"Oh, I know," she said. "I just like coming here to sketch people in crisis."

Peter couldn't help but smile. That was Michelle. She would probably be in the detention room the next time Peter walked in—which would be as soon as he got back to school, because Principal Morita would hear about this, and Peter would be in more trouble.

That was all right with him. He could do all the detention in the world, but first he was going to find the guy in the wing suit and make sure nobody got hurt.

On his way out of school, he grabbed a jar of web fluid from his specially crafted hidey-hole under the lockers. Then he got home, made sure he was alone, and put on the Spider-Suit.

“Hey, Karen,” he said.

“Hi, Peter. How was your Spanish quiz?”

He ignored this. “Listen, I was wondering if you could help me figure out who the guys were under the bridge that night, but I can only kind of remember part of a license plate.”

“I can run facial recognition on the footage of that encounter,” she suggested.

“Footage?”

“Yes, Peter. I record everything you see.”

Now Peter was nervous. “Everything?”

“Everything. It’s called the Baby Monitor Protocol.”

“Of course it is,” Peter said, annoyed. “Um, okay. Just roll it back.”

Peter’s HUD came to life. First it showed a bunch of embarrassing footage of his hamming it up in the Spider-Man suit.

A lot of footage.

“No, no, this is just me messing around. Fast-forward to the arms deal.”

The video feed sped up and reached the scene under the bridge. “Okay, who are the two on the right?” Those were the Vulture’s guys.

“Searching law enforcement databases,” Karen said as boxes appeared around all three faces: the Vulture’s guys and their would-be client. Two of the three faces—the Vulture’s men—grayed out. “No records found for two individuals.” The third face glowed more brightly. “One individual identified. Aaron Davis, age thirty-three. He has a criminal record...and an address here in Queens.”

There we go , Peter thought. That was the lead he needed. “Let’s pay him a visit.”

“Would you like me to activate the Enhanced Interrogation Protocol?”

Peter thought about it for a minute. “Uh, yeah.”



Chapter 18



Peter found Aaron Davis walking up to his car with bags of groceries in a parking garage. The Spider-Drone followed Davis across the garage and hovered near him while he

opened the trunk of his car. That was the moment Peter was waiting for. He webbed Davis's left hand to the trunk lid and dropped from the ceiling. "Remember me?" he growled. The Enhanced Interrogation Protocol was great at making his voice sound deep and threatening. "I need information, and you're going to give it to me."

"All right, chill, okay?" Davis glanced up at the drone, then back at Peter. He was a lot calmer than Peter would have expected. "Wait, what happened to your voice?"

"What do you mean, what happened?"

"I heard you by the bridge. I know what a girl sounds like."

"I'm not a girl! I'm a boy! I mean—a man!"

"I don't care what you are, boy, girl...." Davis put the rest of his groceries in the car. Clearly, Spider-Man's presence wasn't making him nervous at all.

"Come on, man, who is selling these weapons? I need to know," Peter said, almost pleading. Then he remembered he was supposed to be intimidating Davis into talking.

"Give me names or else!"

Davis slammed the trunk. The back window of his car was taped over with a garbage bag; apparently he hadn't had time to fix it since Spider-Man's web had pulled it out. "You ain't never done this before, huh?"

Peter gave up. "Deactivate interrogation mode," he said. Then, in his normal voice, he went on. "Look, man. These guys are selling weapons that are crazy dangerous. They

can't just be out on the streets. If just one of those things can cut Dalmar's bodega in half, imagine what'll happen when—"

Davis held up a hand. "Wait, you know Dalmar's?"

"Best sandwich in Queens."

"Sub Haven's pretty good," Davis pointed out.

"Eh, too much bread."

"I like bread."

"Come on, man, please," Peter said. He didn't have time to argue about sandwiches. Then he gave up and turned to go, muttering to himself about that stupid interrogation mode.

Davis called after him. "The other night, you told that dude 'if you were going to shoot somebody, shoot me.' That was pretty solid. I don't want those weapons in this neighborhood. I got a nephew who lives here."

Spider-Man stopped and turned around. "Who are these guys? What can you tell me about the guy with the wings?"

"Other than he's a psychopath who dresses like a demon? Nothing," Davis said. "I don't know who he is or where he is." Spider-Man leaned against Davis's car and looked up at the ceiling, dejected. "I do know where he's gonna be," Davis added.

Spider-Man straightened up. "Really?"

“Yeah, this crazy dude I used to work for, he’s supposed to be doing a deal with him.”

“Yes!” Peter punched the air and started to head off.

“Hey,” Davis said, stopping Spider-Man before he got carried away. “I didn’t tell you where. You don’t have a location.”

“Yeah, yeah, of course,” Spider-Man said, coming back toward Davis again. He was still getting the hang of this. “Where is it?”

“Can I give you some advice?” Davis asked. Spider-Man nodded. “You gotta get better at this part of the job.”

“What are you saying?” Peter folded his arms and tried to look imposing. “I’m intimidating.”

“Staten Island Ferry,” Davis said. “Eleven.”

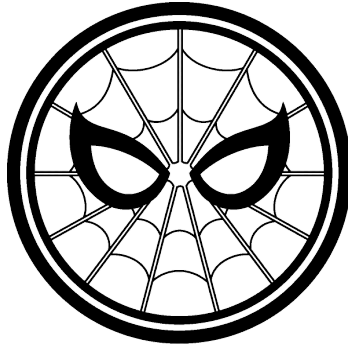
“Hey, that’s soon,” Spider-Man said. He pointed at the webbing on Davis’s hand. “That’s going to dissolve in two hours.”

“No, no, come fix this,” Davis said.

“No, you deserve that.” Spider-Man headed for the exit.

“Hey,” Davis shouted. “Come on, man, I got ice cream in here!”

But Peter was already headed for the Staten Island Ferry.



He barely made the eleven o'clock ferry, jumping off the terminal balcony and swooping toward the ferry's stern with the help of the cool little glider wings. When he was stuck to the outside of the superstructure, Peter got his bearings. He scrambled along the outer hull. "Okay, Karen. Activate Enhanced Reconnaissance Mode."

"Sure thing."

Peter peered through one of the windows, and the suit's HUD highlighted the big bald guy with the power-glove thing. Only he didn't have it now. He was sitting back-to-back with an older guy Peter didn't recognize, talking to him as discreetly as he could. But it was hard to be discreet when Stark-Tech was listening in.

"He's on the aft deck," the older guy said.

"I hate this guy," the bald man said.

"Gargan's a clown, but he pays. I'll watch your back." The bald guy nodded and walked away. Spider-Man looked carefully at the older guy, memorizing his face. He was the leader. Was he the guy in the wing suit? If he was, Spider-Man would find out soon enough.

“Incoming call from May Parker,” Karen said. “Should I route it to your heads-up display?”

“I can’t talk right now,” Peter said quickly. “I’ll call her back.”

He deployed the Spider-Drone. “Keep an eye on that guy,” he instructed. “We can’t let anybody get away this time.”

Swinging up to the top level of the ferry, Peter looked down on the aft deck. Karen scanned the faces and highlighted one of them, a rough-looking guy with a shaved head and a big neck tattoo of a scorpion. “Mac Gargan. Extensive criminal record, including homicide. Would you like me to activate Instant Kill?”

“No! Karen, stop it with the Instant Kill already!”

Below, the bald man approached Gargan and his goons. “White pickup truck,” he said.

Gargan nodded, and one of the goons headed into the ferry toward the vehicle deck.

“Droney, scan the ship,” Spider-Man said. The drone did, finding a white pickup on the lower level. It flew in, giving Peter a great view as Gargan’s goon showed up and someone pointed him at bags of weapons in the truck bed. “Oh, this is too perfect. They’ve got the weapons, buyers, and sellers all in one place,” he said to Karen. He could nail them all at once!

“Incoming call from Tony Stark,” Karen said.

“No, no, don’t answer,” Peter said, but she already had. Stark’s face appeared on the HUD.

“Mr. Parker. Got a second?”



Chapter 19



Uh, no,” Peter said, glad Stark couldn’t see where he was. The video was a close-up of his face inside the mask. “I’m actually at school.”

“Nice work in DC,” Stark said. “My dad never really gave me a lot of support, and I’m just trying to break the cycle—”

Wow , Peter thought. *That was nice*. But he really didn’t have time to talk. “Uh, I’m kind of in the middle of something right now.”

“Don’t cut me off when I’m trying to compliment you,” Stark said. “Anyway, great things are about to happen.” The ferry horn went off and Stark stopped. “What is that?”

“Uh, I’m at band practice.”

“That’s odd. Happy told me you quit band six weeks ago.” On another part of the HUD, Peter saw Gargan taking the keys to the truck from the bald guy, right below him. The deal was happening!

“Uh, I gotta go. End call!” Peter hung up on a startled Tony Stark and immediately webbed the keys out of Gargan’s hand. “I’ll take those!”

Then he dropped down onto the vehicle deck, where three of Gargan’s men were waiting. “Sorry, guys, wrong ferry. The illegal-weapons-deal ferry was at two thirty.”

They all pulled guns. *Not comedy fans, these guys*, Peter thought. He webbed two of them, then used the webs to slingshot himself forward and kick the third. The goon went flying off the stern, and Peter caught him with another web, which smashed him back against the hull. Peter vaulted back over the first two and swung them hard into the wall.

All of a sudden the bald guy had the power-glove thing on, and he barely missed Spider-Man with it. His punch smashed into the railing with a crackle of electricity. He struggled to get the gauntlet free, and Peter webbed it to the railing.

“I gotta say, the other guy was way better with that thing,” he said casually. “I’m shocked.” He chuckled to himself at the joke. *Shocked, heh*. Then he flipped a web grenade over

his shoulder; when it went off, it pinned Gargan's last goon to the wall back on the vehicle deck.

He turned at another noise from near the truck and saw the older guy, right there, staring at him. Spider-Man started to go after him, but out of nowhere guys with guns were on the upper deck and pouring from the side doors. "FBI!" they screamed. "Freeze!"

"Whoa, FBI?"

Karen started to explain what the FBI was, but Peter cut her off. "Yeah, I know, but what are they doing here?"

She never got a chance to answer, because right then, the wing suit tore through the roof of a van parked by the truck. The Vulture! The older guy *was* the Vulture. He hovered inside, spreading his wings and holding up a big gun powered by one of the Chitauri cores.

"Get out of the way!" Spider-Man shouted, pushing the FBI agents as the Vulture flew into the space above the stern. He fired a warning shot to scatter the group of agents, then aimed another blast at the railing where the Shocker was still trying to get free. The burst of energy cut through the railing, freeing him to make a break for the stairs.

Spider-Man webbed the Vulture's leg and stuck the other end to the closest parked car. The Vulture was firing the Chitauri weapon at him, but Spider-Man kept dodging and webbing him. If he could get the wings tangled, or even the little rotor blades that powered the wings...

But the Vulture started snipping the webs with the sharp edges of the wings. He kept firing, and explosions rang out inside the ferry. Passengers screamed and scattered.

Peter had to get that weapon out of his hands. He shot another web that entangled its muzzle. “Activate Taser webs!” he shouted, and an electric shock traveled up the web and sizzled through the wing suit. The Vulture jerked and dropped the weapon. It clanged on the deck and kept firing randomly, slashing holes in the walls and ceiling of the vehicle deck. Peter tried to grab it without getting shot. That didn’t work, so he just buried it in webbing, sticking it to the deck. It vibrated and glowed.

The Vulture, hovering just off the stern, called out, “You’re messing with things you don’t understand.”

Then he swooped away, grabbing Schultz, and in the next second the Chitauri weapon overloaded. Purple energy lanced out along the midline of the ferry, burning through the hull. The gun kept firing and then exploded, blasting open the back of the ship. Weakened by the energy beam, the ferry began to split in half from aft to bow. The two sides tilted apart, and water spurted up into the vehicle deck.

Peter sprang into action. “Give me a scan of the ship and highlight all the strongest points!” he shouted to Karen. She did, and he started to run from the back of the ship to the front, webbing the strong points together in a race against time to keep the ship from splitting completely in half. He fired web after web, using some lines to get him down the length of the ship faster, and praying he would have

enough. When he got to the bow, where most of the passengers were clustered, the webs were stretched tight.... But the ship was holding. Its hull groaned, and water was still coming in, but it wasn't going to sink right away.

"Great job, Peter," Karen said. "You were ninety-eight percent successful."

"Ninety-eight?" Peter echoed. On the HUD, a strong point still showed up red. He'd missed one.

A passenger started to clap. "Yeah, Spider-Man!" Then more joined in. Peter was just beginning to relax when he heard a sharp *ping* !

One of the webs had snapped. Soon others followed, one after the other, like guitar strings wound too tightly. The ferry started to shift and tilt again.

"No!" Peter shouted. He leaped out over the churning water between the two halves of the ship and grabbed a broken web. With his other hand he shot as many webs as he could, and then he held on for dear life, straining, holding the ship together just by himself. He thought it wasn't going to work....Then he thought it might....And then he felt the two parts of the hull shift and come a bit closer together. The deck began to level out. Peter couldn't believe it. He'd done it! He was stronger than he thought.

But pretty soon he felt the ship's two parts coming together faster. The webs went slack. Peter dropped to the deck, puzzled....And then he saw Iron Man's face in the ship's window.

“Hi, Spider-Man,” Iron Man said with sarcastic fake cheer. “Band practice, was it?”

He fired his repulsors, pushing one half of the ferry toward the other. The gap closed. Then dozens of repulsor drones appeared and clamped onto both sides of the ferry, pushing it back together and leveling it out.

“Yeah, Iron Man!” yelled the same passenger who had just cheered Spider-Man.

Iron Man flew down into the vehicle deck. Peter swung after him and watched as Iron Man fired wrist beams, welding the hull back together along the seam where the Chitauri weapon had split it apart. Now the passengers were really cheering.

Spider-Man chased Iron Man all the way to the ferry’s bow and then up onto its mast. “Mr. Stark! Hey, Mr. Stark! Is there anything I can do?”

Iron Man finished his welding job and hovered over the smoking, listing ferry. “I think you’ve done enough,” he said, and flew away toward Manhattan.



Chapter 20



Back at the warehouse, Toomes and his crew tried to figure out what to do next. They'd lost all the gear from the truck, and as Mason said, they didn't have any more raw materials to work with. Schultz was shook up and ready to bail, and he said so the minute they'd all gotten together again. "So that's it?" Toomes asked. "You just going to run?"

"Feds were waiting for us," Schultz said. "Now we're on Iron Man's radar? Yeah, I'm running. You should, too."

"You know we can't do that."

"So now what?" Schultz asked.

Toomes realized it was time to take a chance. For eight years they'd been able to work under the radar, but that couldn't last forever. Now they needed to make one last big score....And there was only one way to do that. All the trucks heading for Damage Control would have extra security now that they knew someone had broken into one of them. But the last big cache of stuff moving out of Avengers Tower to the Damage Control vault was going by air. Toomes hadn't wanted to take that chance before, but now he didn't see any other possibility.

"Mason," he said. "Can you get that high-altitude seal up and running in time?"

Mason stood up. "Seriously?" He'd been talking about the high-altitude seal ever since they first learned that Tony Stark had sold Avengers Tower. They knew some of the holdings in the tower were too precious and delicate to move by truck, so Stark would use a plane. And since

Mason never left the workshop, he'd wanted to take the risky shot from the beginning. Toomes, who had to go out into the field and take the risks personally, was more careful.

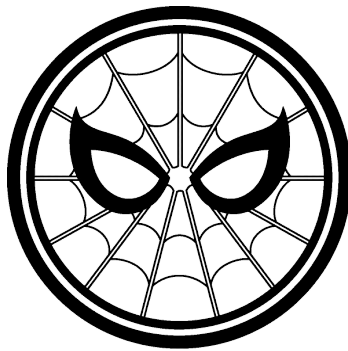
Or had been. Now they couldn't afford to be careful anymore.

"Yes," Mason said. "You will not regret this."

Toomes turned back to Schultz. "You in?"

A little electricity was in the air as they considered this new possibility. It might be dangerous, it might be foolish, but all three felt the thrill that came with the idea that they just might pull it off.

After a moment, Schultz nodded.



Peter sat on the roof of the building that vented the Brooklyn-Battery Tunnel, mask off, watching a swarm of tugboats and first responders around the crippled ferry. It was still sinking, but slowly, and there was time to evacuate the passengers. The Iron Man armor hovered just past the edge of the roof. "Previously on *Peter Screws the Pooch* ,"

Stark said, “I tell you to stay away from this, and then you hacked a multimillion-dollar suit and did the one thing I told you not to do.”

Peter nodded. He knew where this was going, and he deserved it. “Is everyone okay?” he asked.

“No thanks to you.”

Peter fumed. At least he’d tried to do something while Stark and the Avengers ignored him and acted like he was a stupid kid. “No thanks to me? Those weapons were out there, and I tried to tell you about it, but you wouldn’t listen! None of this would have happened if you had just listened to me!” Stark didn’t say anything, which made Peter even angrier. “If you really cared, you’d be here.”

The Iron Man suit opened up, revealing a very angry Tony Stark. He stepped out of the suit toward Peter as Peter took a step back. “I did listen, kid,” he said. “Who do you think called the FBI? Do you know that I was the only one who believed in you? Everyone else said I was crazy to recruit a fourteen-year-old kid.”

“I’m fifteen.”

“No! This is where you zip it, all right? The adult is talking. What if somebody had died today? Different story, right, because that’s on you. And if you die...” Stark spread his arms. “I feel like that’s on me. I don’t need that on my conscience.”

“I’m sorry. I know. I just...I wanted to be like you.”

He paused, watching Stark react. After a moment, Tony said, “And I wanted you to be better.” Then he got control of his emotions and briskly moved on. “Okay, it’s not working out. I’m gonna need the suit back.”

“What? For how long?”

“Forever.”

No , Peter thought. This was worse than he’d feared. Much worse. “Please, Mr. Stark. I need it. You don’t understand. I’m nothing without this suit.”

“If you’re nothing without the suit, then you shouldn’t have it. Okay?” Stark looked off to one side. “God, I sound like my dad.”

Peter stood, humiliated and sad, in front of his idol. He knew he couldn’t keep the suit if Stark wanted it back, but what would he be without it? Just Peter Parker, again. One more geek at Midtown. And on top of that...

“I don’t have any other clothes,” he said miserably.



Chapter 21



Stark dropped him off on Atlantic Avenue in Queens, not far from his apartment, and Peter walked home wearing a cheesy tourist shirt and pajama pants. On the way, he

passed a laundromat. The TV was playing footage of Spider-Man webbing the Staten Island Ferry together over the caption: *Spider-Man: The New Avenger?*

Fat chance , Peter thought. Seeing that made him feel even worse about how things had gone between him and Stark.

He walked up the stairs and out of reflex reached for his keys. But he didn't have them. So he had to knock on the door. May opened it immediately. He could see warring emotions on her face: relief, worry, anger. She walked away into the living room. "I've been calling you all day, but you didn't answer your phone," she began. "You can't do that. And then this ferry thing happens? I've called five police stations. Five. I called your friends, I tried—"

"May, I'm fine. It's okay. Just relax, okay?"

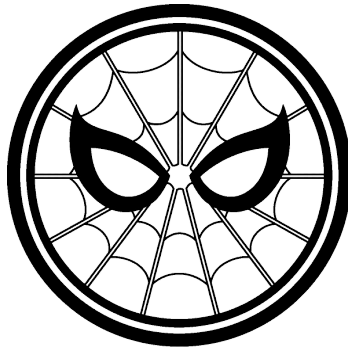
Right away he knew that was the wrong thing to say. She stiffened and said, "I know you left detention. I know you left the hotel room in Washington, DC. I know you sneak out of this house every night. That's *not* fine. Peter, you have to tell me what's going on. Just lay it out. It's just me and you."

"I lost the Stark internship," he said. It was the only thing he could think of to tell her. Even though it was a lie, it had some truth in it, and she would understand.

"What? What happened?"

"I just thought I could work really hard, and he would...you know...but I screwed it up."

He sat on the couch, and she came over to him and ruffled one hand through his hair. “It’s okay,” she said. “You know, I’m not trying to ruin your life. I used to sneak out, too.” She hugged him for a moment, then sighed and said, “Go take a shower. You smell.”



Peter tried to stay on the straight and narrow. But first he had to sit through another lecture from Principal Morita.

Ned was waiting outside again. “Did you get expelled?” he asked. “Do you have to go to that high school on Forty-Sixth, where the principal has a crossbow?”

“I’m pretty sure that’s an urban myth. And I’m not expelled.”

“You are so lucky.”

“Yeah,” Peter said. “Lucky.”

Serving his detention, Peter watched the Captain America videos like everybody else. He didn’t make web fluid in chemistry anymore. One day that week, on the way home, he deleted the videos of his trip to Leipzig. That had happened to someone else. He wasn’t Spider-Man anymore.

He was just plain, old Peter Parker. And maybe that was enough.

The next day, walking to class, he ran into Liz in the atrium by the music classroom. “I thought you had calculus fifth period,” he said.

“Yeah, just doing some Homecoming stuff,” she said with a shrug.

He nodded. There was an awkward silence. He broke it by saying, “Hey, I just wanted to apologize about the whole Decathlon thing—”

“It’s fine,” she interrupted. “Last week, nothing was more important to me than the Decathlon. But then I almost died.”

I know, Peter thought. *I was there*. “Still, it wasn’t cool, especially because...” He looked down at the floor, gathered his nerve, and went on. “I like you.”

She smiled. “I know.”

“You do?”

“You’re terrible at keeping secrets.”

“Yeah, I think you’d be surprised,” he said, wishing he could tell her his biggest secret. “Well, I’d say we should hang out, but I’m in detention for, like, ever.”

“Uh-huh.”

Peter didn't want the conversation to end that way, though, and he noticed the giant Homecoming banner on the wall behind Liz. The dance was Friday. "I'm sure you already have a date for Homecoming."

"Actually, I spent so much time planning it, I never got around to that part," she said.

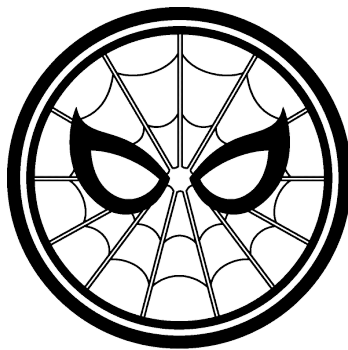
Peter sensed an opening. "Oh. Um...you want to go with me?"

"Sure," she said right away. "Why not?"

Peter couldn't believe it. "Really? I mean...cool."

She nodded. "Cool."

They both laughed for a moment. Then it was time to get back to class.



After school, Peter got home as fast as he could, barging through the front door. Before May could even say hi from the kitchen, Peter came up to her and said, "I need help."

Once he explained, May swung into action. Peter might not have known anything about how to get ready for a dance,

but she did. She found a set of Uncle Ben's cuff links and bought him a new shirt so he could wear them. She showed him how to use cologne. She even tried to teach him how to dance, with...mixed results. The night of the dance, a few days later, she helped him tie his tie and put on the cuff links, and she remembered to get Liz a corsage from the florist around the corner.

Then she stepped back, looking at him in his suit and tie, and smiled. "I think you're ready."



Chapter 22



May stopped the car outside Liz's house and said, "It's game day. So what's the plan?"

Nervous, Peter ticked off items on the list he and May had worked out. "Open the door for her, pull out her chair, tell her she looks nice." May gave him a look. "But not too much, because that's creepy."

She nodded. "You got this."

He did, didn't he? Peter smiled and repeated, "I got this." Then he stepped out of the car and walked up to Liz's house. He took a deep breath and knocked on the door. After a few seconds, it opened....And Peter froze.

The man standing in the doorway was the boss from the Staten Island Ferry. The man in the wing suit.

The Vulture.

"You must be Peter Parker," he said with a smile. "I'm Liz's dad." He extended his hand, and after a moment, Peter remembered he was supposed to shake it. Toomes looked down. "Hell of a grip. You coming in?"

He stood aside, and Peter entered the house, head spinning with the realization that of all the people in the world who could have been the leader of a gang of alien-weapon dealers, it had to be Liz's dad. What was he going to do?

Was this some kind of trap?

He felt a little better when Liz's mom came out to greet him. "Hi, Peter. You look very handsome."

“Thank you, ma’am,” he said. She leaned over to Toomes and made a joke Peter couldn’t hear. Toomes stood at the kitchen island, with Peter waiting in the dining room past it. “You’re a little pale,” Toomes noted. “What’s your drink, Pete? Bourbon, scotch?”

“I’m not old enough to drink.” Peter was barely keeping himself together. Did Toomes recognize him? Was that possible?

If so, it didn’t show. “That was a test,” he said, smiling. “And you passed.”

“Dad,” Liz said as she made her entrance, “please don’t embarrass me.”

Peter turned and saw her. She looked incredible. She was way out of his league. And she was going to Homecoming with him. Even standing next to a man who had tried to kill him multiple times, Peter couldn’t believe it.

“You look beautiful, honey,” Toomes said. “Doesn’t she, Pete?”

“Y-yeah,” Peter stuttered.

“Wow, smooth,” Toomes joked. “Well, then. I’m your chauffeur. Shall we shove off?”

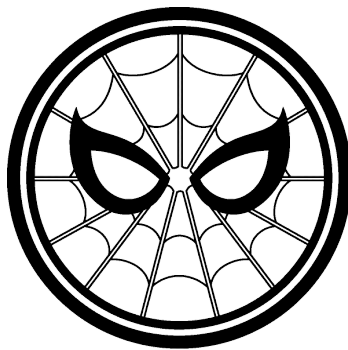
“Wait, wait, wait! Pictures!” Liz’s mom pushed Peter and Liz together. They posed for several photos. Peter struggled to keep his cool and remember he was supposed to smile.

“Are you wearing cologne?” Liz asked him quietly.

“What? No, it’s just soap,” he lied. It was cologne, but he didn’t want to admit it. Turning to Toomes, he said, “You don’t have to drive us, really.”

“It’s okay. I’m going out of town on business; I can drop you on the way.”

Liz’s mom put down her camera and hugged them both. “Awww ...Have fun, you two.” Then she kissed Toomes. “See you in a couple of days.”



It was quiet in the car. Liz definitely picked up on it, but Peter didn’t know how to break the tension. His mind raced as he tried to figure out his next move. “So what’re you gonna be when you grow up, Pete?” Toomes asked.

“I’m not really sure,” Peter said.

“Don’t grill him, Dad,” Liz said.

“I thought all you kids at that school had the next ten years of your life mapped out.”

“I’m still a sophomore.”

“Peter got an internship with Tony Stark himself,” Liz said with pride. “So I don’t think he’ll have to worry.”

That perked Toomes up. He looked at Peter in the rearview mirror. “Stark, huh?”

Uneasy, Peter said, “Actually, I’m not interning for him anymore.”

“Really?” Liz sounded surprised.

“Yeah, it was...” He tried to be casual. “It was boring.”

“Boring? You got to know Spider-Man.”

Peter glanced up at the rearview mirror. Toomes was staring at him. “Is that so?” Toomes said.

“Well—not really, I just talked to him a couple of times.”

After a pause, Toomes said, “I’ve seen you around, right, Pete?” He looked right at Peter, barely keeping an eye on the road.

“He does Academic Decathlon with me,” Liz explained. “And he was at my party.”

“Quite a night,” Toomes said, and all of a sudden Peter had the feeling Toomes wasn’t talking about the party at all.

“Yep,” he said, trying to keep his voice level. “Super fun.”

“You were only there for, like, two seconds,” Liz complained.

“Really?” Toomes said. “Where’d you go, Pete?”

“Nowhere,” Peter said too quickly. “I mean, I stayed a while.”

Toomes was still staring at him as the car stopped at a red light. “Terrible what you guys went through in DC,” he said. “You must have been pretty happy to see your pal Spider-Man in that elevator, huh?”

Peter glanced at Liz, then out the window. He was sure he was caught. But all he could do was try to bluff.

“Um, well, actually, I just saw him from the ground,” he said. “I wasn’t up there, so...”

“Dad,” Liz said. “The light.”

It was green. Toomes drove on. They didn’t say anything else until they pulled up in front of Midtown. The bass line from the dance’s music boomed out of the gym and onto the street. Kids were piling out of cars and posing for pictures all around them.

Liz opened her door, but when Peter tried to open his, he found it was still locked. “This is as far as you go,” Toomes said. He locked eyes with Peter, who tried not to show how terrified he was. “Gumdrop, you head in. I’m gonna give Peter the ‘Dad talk.’”

Liz rolled her eyes. “Don’t let him intimidate you,” she said, and headed toward the dance.

Easy for you to say , Peter thought.

When they were alone in the car Toomes asked, “Does she know?”

“Know what?” Peter was still trying to bluff.

“So she doesn’t. Close to the vest, I admire that.” Toomes grinned. “Got a few secrets myself.”

Peter was trying to look around for a way out without letting Toomes know he was doing that. Toomes started to chuckle as a thought occurred to him. “Of all the reasons I didn’t want Liz to date, I never imagined this one....” He cracked a smile again, then got serious. “Nothing’s more important than family, Peter. You saved my daughter’s life. I don’t forget something like that. So I’m gonna give you one chance. Walk through those doors, forget any of this happened, and never interfere with my business again.” He shifted farther around on his seat, leaning closer to Peter. “If you do, I’ll kill you. I’ll kill you dead, and everyone you love. That’s what I’d do to protect my family, Pete. Understand?”

Peter tried to lock eyes with Toomes, stare him down, but he couldn’t. He looked away and nodded.

Toomes smiled again. “Hey, what do you say? I just saved your life, Pete.”

Utterly defeated, Peter paused. Finally, he said, “Thank you.”

“You’re welcome. Now go show my daughter a great time.” After a pause, Toomes added the classic dad caution: “But

not too great.”



Chapter 23



Numb, Peter made his way past the crowd and into the school. The gym was thumping with music. He stood outside the glass gym doors, looking through at the dancing

kids. Liz laughed with her friends. Ned was there with Michelle, both of them looking happy. Ned waved at him.

Peter took a deep breath and went in. His mind spun, and it was hard to concentrate, but he knew what he had to do. When he reached the group, Liz saw he looked upset about something. “Don’t worry,” she said. “His bark is worse than his bite. He’s just being a good dad.”

Peter knew he could let the whole thing go and stay with his friends. Just as he wanted to do at the hotel pool in DC. But he hadn’t done it there, and he couldn’t do it here, either. He knew if he went and caught Toomes, it would break Liz’s heart—and if he didn’t, he would always have to live with being a coward.

“I have to go,” he said.

Liz’s smile faded. She didn’t say anything. She just looked at him, stunned and hurt under the strobing lights in the gym. “I’m so sorry,” Peter said. “You don’t deserve this.”

Then he was moving again, back out of the gym and down the hall to the row of lockers where he kept his old, homemade suit. He picked it up and kept going, changing on the fly. *Just like old times*, he thought. *Before Leipzig, before Tony Stark, when I was just trying to do the right thing.* He burst out a side door and into the bus parking lot.

He paused there to strap on his old, homemade web shooters when he got a sense that someone was behind him. He turned, still trying to get the web shooter buckled, and—

BAM! He ran straight into a punch from the Shocker gauntlet. The crackle of energy and the force of the punch knocked him sprawling across the asphalt.

He looked up and saw...what was his name? The bald guy from the ship. He loomed over Peter, brandishing the gauntlet. "He warned you," he said. Then he noticed what Peter was wearing. Just an old red hoodie and some tights, with a cheap-looking ski mask and goggles. "What's with the costume? Laundry day?"

Peter ignored the crack. "Whatever you guys are planning, I'm gonna stop it."

"No, kid. You're not." His voice almost sounded pitying.

Spider-Man rolled and leaped for the nearest web shooter. The bald man didn't try to race him. Instead, he shocked the closest bus, knocking it into Spider-Man. Peter clung to the side and leaped clear just as it crashed into another parked bus.

"I wasn't sure about this thing at first, but..." the Shocker said, looking impressed at the gauntlet.

Spider-Man started for the web shooter again, but Schultz kicked it away. "I think I like it this way, where I've got my toy, and you don't have yours."

He charged the gauntlet, ready to strike again. Peter tried to spring past it, but it punched him square in the face. Peter crashed through the windshield of a bus, which went tumbling across the parking lot as the bald guy blasted it

again. Peter staggered out of the bus, his goggles askew. He tried to adjust them.

“Why did he send you here?” Peter groaned. Had Toomes lied about the second chance? Was he really so psycho that he would set up an ambush at the Homecoming dance?

Schultz raised the gauntlet for a final, fatal strike. “Guess you’ll never know.”

But just as he was about to bring the gauntlet down, *THWIP!* The gauntlet was webbed! He looked up in shock. Peter followed the line of the web...right back to Ned, standing with one of the web shooters strapped around his own wrist.

“Nice shot!” he called.

Ned looked frustrated. “I was aiming for his face!”

Spider-Man grabbed the web and ripped the gauntlet from the guy’s arm. In one motion, Peter shoved him up against a bus, scooped up the other web shooter, and webbed the bald man to the side of the bus.

“Ned,” Peter said as he took the other web shooter from him, “the guy with the wings is Liz’s dad!”

Ned’s eyes got wide. “What?!”

Strapping both web shooters on, Peter kept talking. “He’s planning something big. Tonight! I need you to get ahold of Happy Hogan, Mr. Stark’s head of security. And get to a computer and track down my phone.”

“You need your phone now?” Ned wondered.

“I’ll explain in a sec!” Peter said. “I gotta go stop him!”

He webbed a streetlamp and swung up into the night. Watching him go, Ned couldn’t help himself. Caught in the moment, he shouted, “Go get him, Spider-Man!”

Around the front of the school, Spider-Man dropped onto the hood of Flash Thompson’s car just as Flash pulled up. Flash screamed in surprise. “I need your car and your phone,” Peter said, trying to disguise his voice.

“What? Uh, yeah, sure, I—”

Spider-Man pulled Flash out of the driver’s seat and jumped in. He drove away, scraping against a fence along the way. Flash was probably already boasting about having helped Spider-Man. Trying not to crash, Peter called Ned, who was in the school library, sitting in a swivel chair, watching a tracking dot on a monitor. That was Peter’s phone.

When Ned’s phone went off, his caller ID showed Flash Thompson’s number. *Weird*, he thought. But he answered. “Go for Ned.”

“I need you to track my phone!” Peter said.

Ned looked at the monitor. “Yeah, but who has it?”

“It’s in the back of Liz’s dad’s car.”

“Genius move!” Ned shouted. “Okay, he just passed the GameStop on Jackson Avenue.”

“How do you turn on the headlights? I’m in Flash’s car.”

Ned swiveled over to another computer. “I’ll pull up the specs.” He had seen Flash’s car. Slick. “Heh, you stole Flash’s car. Awesome.”

In the phone, Spider-Man screamed and shouted to another car, “Sorry!”

“Peter? Are you okay?” Ned asked.

“I’ve only driven in parking lots with May. This is a huge step up. Gotten through to Happy yet?”

“Working on it. Gotta back-door their phone system.” Ned swiveled to another monitor. His exuberance got the better of him again and he lifted both arms in the air, turning in the chair. “Guy in the chair!”

He got the video call connected while he swiped through the specs for Flash’s car. “Hello?” Happy Hogan appeared on the monitor. “Who is this?” He looked like he was at an airport. There was striping on the pavement and the high whine of air-turbine engines.

“Mr. Happy, it’s Ned!”

“Who?”

“I’m an associate of Peter Parker! He has something very important to tell you!”

“You gotta be kidding me,” Happy said, and hung up.

Peter hadn't heard any of it. "How we coming on those headlights?" he yelled.

"Round knob to the left of the steering wheel! Turn clockwise!"

Spider-Man turned the knob. The lights came on. "Okay, perfect!" Driving was so much easier when you could see. "So where is my phone now?"

"He stopped in that old industrial park in Brooklyn."

"That doesn't make sense," Peter said, remembering the conversation at Toomes's house before the dance. "He said he was going out of town."

"Weird. I reached Mr. Happy, and he didn't sound glad to hear from me. He was surrounded by boxes."

"What?" Spider-Man had a realization. "Oh my God... moving day...I gotta stop him!"



Chapter 24



Happy couldn't believe Peter had friends trying to call him on moving day.

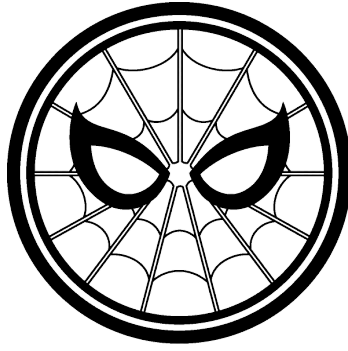
But more important, he had the final moving day shipments to make. Final and most important. All around him, armed security personnel pushed crates of dangerous tech—Chitauri, Hydra, Jotun, you name it—up a ramp and onto a big custom-built VTOL jet. The jet tested its cloaking as part of its preflight routine. Perfect. If Happy hadn't known it was there, he never would have seen it.

“Wheels up in eight minutes!” It occurred to him that this particular plane didn't have any wheels. “Well, not wheels, but you get it!” His phone buzzed. When he saw who was calling, he answered. “Director Hoag.”

“The vault is ready,” she said, getting right to the point. “Are we on schedule?”

“Yeah.” Happy looked at his tablet as he talked, running down the list of secure items that still awaited loading. “We just have to load Tony's old Hulkbuster armor, prototypes for Cap's new shield, and a—” He squinted at the next item on the list. “Meg-ing...” He gave up trying to pronounce it. “Thor's magic belt.”

Eight minutes. He couldn't wait to have it all done. The new Avengers HQ upstate was nice, and Happy planned on relaxing there after the big move.



“Okay, you’re getting close. It’s on your right,” Ned said.

“What?”

“On your right!”

Peter saw the turn, way too close. He wasn’t going to make it....But he had to try. He dragged the wheel hard to the right and at the same time fired a web out the passenger-side window. The web snagged a street sign, and the car squealed through a hard right turn. It banged over the curb and fishtailed out of control, skidding on its side for almost a block. Then it came to rest and tipped back onto its tires down a dead-end side street.

“Peter. Are you okay?”

“Yeah,” Peter panted. “Just keep trying to get through to Happy.”

He hung up and moved slowly toward Toomes’s warehouse. The big loading-bay doors were closed, but he found a vent hatch in the roof and lowered himself down through it. *So this was their lair* , he thought. Inside was a huge central space and smaller offices and workshops off to the side. Peter approached a workshop bench with tool marks all

over its surface. It was mostly cleared off—except for a couple of monitors left on. Peter took a closer look.

One of them showed Avengers Tower in night vision and infrared. A large jet was visible on the tower's rooftop helipad.

Another screen showed the airspace over New York City and Long Island. It calculated flight paths based on the first motion of a plane taking off from Avengers Tower.

Spider-Man felt a brief rush of excitement. He was right! Toomes was trying to hijack that airplane and capture its payload. If he could do that...

He heard a noise from the far end of the warehouse and headed for it. In the light of a single lamp, Adrian Toomes stood at a workbench. "Hey!" Peter called out. "Surprised?"

Toomes turned around. "Oh, hey, Pete. I didn't hear you come in."

"It's over! I've got you."

"You know, I gotta tell you, Pete. I really, really admire your grit. I see why Liz likes you." Toomes was putting on his coat like he was headed out on an ordinary errand. Behind him, an engine block hung on a chain from the ceiling. He took a drink from a beer on the bench and added, "When you first came to the house, I wasn't sure, but I get it now."

"How can you do this to her?" Peter asked.

“To her?” Toomes seemed surprised. “I’m not doing anything to her, Pete. I’m doing this for her.” He went to pick up the beer again, but Peter knocked it out of his hand with a web.

“Peter, you’re young. You don’t understand how the world works.”

“Yeah, but I understand that selling weapons to criminals is wrong.”

“How do you think your buddy Stark paid for that tower? Or any of his other little toys. Those people, Pete, the rich and the powerful, they do whatever they want. Guys like us, you and me? They don’t care about us. We build their roads, we fight all their wars and everything, but they don’t care about us. We have to pick up after them; we have to eat their table scraps. That’s how it is. I know you know what I’m talking about, Pete.”

There was truth in what Toomes said. Peter knew it, but he also knew Toomes was twisting it to justify what he had done...and what he was planning to do. “Why are you telling me this?” Peter asked.

“Because I want you to understand.” For a moment, Toomes seemed sincere. Then his expression changed. “And I needed a little time to get her airborne.”



Chapter 25



With an earsplitting screech, a new Vulture wing suit smashed through the wall. It was bigger and meaner-looking than the last one, with larger rotor engines and

wings heavy enough to destroy concrete pillars as it dove at Peter. He flipped and swung and dodged, avoiding every pass. Was this the best Toomes had? Peter could do this all day.

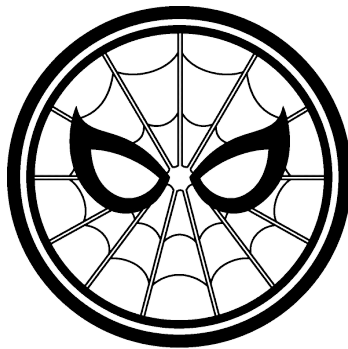
“I’m sorry, Peter,” Toomes said.

“What are you talking about?” he taunted the Vulture.

“That thing hasn’t even touched me yet.”

“True,” Toomes conceded with a shrug. But he was smiling, and Peter didn’t like that at all. “Then again,” Toomes added, “it wasn’t really trying to.”

The suit’s wings shattered another row of pillars. Peter looked up. Before he could move, a huge section of the warehouse roof collapsed directly on him.

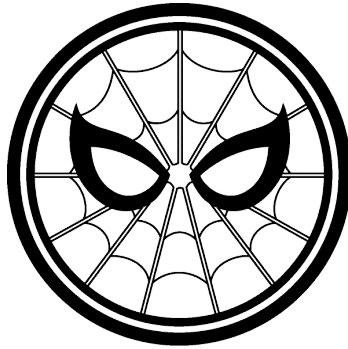


Toomes felt a little bad about what he’d done to the kid. But you could only give people so many chances before you had to take drastic steps to protect your own.

Outside the warehouse, he looked across the river at Avengers Tower. Mason was telling him that the target plane was powering up. The new wing suit hovered behind

him, and he spread his arms. It clamped and latched itself into place.

Now it was time for the big score.



Peter woke up with water dripping on his face and the rubble of the collapsed roof settling around him. He was pinned and could barely breathe. He struggled and cried out for help, but he was alone.

No one was coming. Peter yelled again, desperate for someone, anyone, to hear him and help him. But he was well and truly alone.

He started to panic, thrashing against the huge blocks of concrete that pinned him, but he couldn't get out. The Vulture was on his way to hijack the Stark plane, and Peter Parker was under a pile of rubble, helpless and afraid. He could die there and nobody would find him. Would May even know what happened to him?

He screamed again for help.

If he only had the suit...

Tony Stark's words came to mind. *If you're nothing without the suit, then you shouldn't have it.*

Okay , Peter thought. *Maybe not. Maybe it isn't the suit that counts. It's me. Either I can do this or I can't.*

Let's find out.

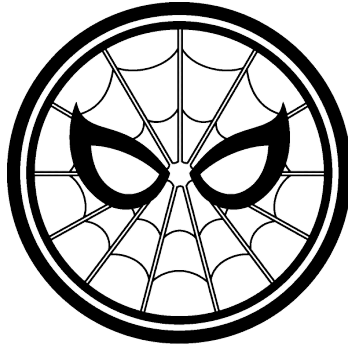
He braced himself and screamed out with the effort as he shoved up against the huge piece of rooftop machinery over his head. "Come on, Peter," he said. "Come on, Spider-Man!"

Slowly, the debris shifted. Peter screamed louder and pushed harder. Every muscle in his body got close to its breaking point....But he was moving it. He thought he felt something in his shoulder pop, but he was moving it. He was tilting it slowly up....

With a thunderous crash, it tipped over and Peter was free!

Panting and sore, he scrambled over the rest of the wreckage. He had to find the Vulture. He burst out the loading doors and turned toward the side of the warehouse that faced the river and Manhattan. The Vulture was there, spreading his wings and powering up the wing engines.

With a last, desperate leap, Peter shot out a web. The Vulture took off, and Spider-Man secretly took off with him.



The Stark jet swung up and away from the rooftop landing pad on Avengers Tower. The remote pilot engaged the cloaking system, and the jet became invisible to the naked eye....But Adrian Toomes had other ways of tracking it, thanks to Mason's tech. "I have visual on the plane," he said, "but I'm feeling a little resistance."

"Probably just drag on the new turbines," Mason advised. They hadn't had time to flight-test them enough, so little problems were bound to crop up. As long as the high-altitude phasing sensors worked, it wouldn't make any difference.

"Look out for the cloaking cameras," Mason said as Toomes dropped in behind the jet. "Stay in the blind spots." Those were back by the tail, where turbulence from the engines made it impossible to mount a camera.

Toomes sped up and grabbed hold of the underside of the jet's fuselage. "Deploying high-altitude vacuum seal," Mason said, like it was something he'd been waiting to say his whole life.

"This better work, Mason," Toomes said, grunting with the effort of hanging on to the jet at two thousand feet in the

air. The wing suit folded around him in a protective cocoon, clamping onto the jet and letting Toomes place the phasing sensors. Part of the jet's underbelly phased out and Toomes pulled himself up into its cargo hold.

The first order of business was to override the jet's security. It was unmanned, so he didn't have to kill anyone, but he did have to make sure nobody tracking it noticed when the jet made an unexpected turn. Toomes broke into the cockpit and wired a device into the control panel. "Cloning transponder signal," he said.

Mason answered. "Deploying drone decoy." The drone would pretend it was the plane on its original course. Meanwhile, Toomes was reprogramming the jet to land somewhere else, where he could go through its contents at his leisure.

He entered the new coordinates and the jet banked away to the east, while the drone continued on. No alerts went off.

Toomes grinned with satisfaction. They had done it. He was going to be set for life.

He went back into the jet's cargo area and popped open crates to check out what was inside. Racks of Chitauri weapons. An entire case of arc reactors. Old Iron Man armor. It went on and on. More stuff than any one man could ever use...but not more than one man could sell. Toomes was already mentally matching some items to potential buyers when an alarm went off. He looked over at the phased section of the jet's underbelly and saw a

powerful wind sucking out through it. Something had loosened the wing suit's cocoon.

That wasn't going to work for Toomes.



Chapter 26



Peter had barely hung on to the cloaking panels on the outside of the jet when it made its turn, and he almost fell off again when he tried to pull the wing suit loose. That must have been how Toomes got inside, and Peter had to get inside with him.

He got a tiny gap open between the wings and the fuselage, but he couldn't pull the suit loose. Frustrated, he started to look for another way in. Then the suit, attached to Toomes, sprang away from the bottom of the jet, and its wings spread.

Uh-oh , Peter thought. The Vulture had spotted him. The phased part of the hull was gone. He was stuck in a three-

hundred-mile-per-hour wind, and the Vulture was coming at him.

Toomes dragged a bladed wing tip down the fuselage toward Spider-Man, kicking fragments of the camouflage panels loose, which shot past Peter. Some hit the intake vent on the nearest engine, shattering some of its turbine blades. Peter tried to leap out of the Vulture's way, and he almost ended up in the engine himself. He landed on its intake cone, and the Vulture smashed through the engine mount. Peter shot out a web and hung on as the line latched onto the wing and the flaming engine fell away into the night. Sparks and fire were shooting from one whole side of the jet now.

Spider-Man crawled to the top of the jet, trying to stay clear of the tail engine's intake. The Vulture slammed down near him, slashing with his wings and mechanical talons. He was trying to force Peter into the engine. It sparked and started to burn from all the debris hitting it, and Peter barely pulled himself free from the suction.

The plane shuddered and started to dive as the tail engine flamed out. The cloaking panels flickered, and suddenly the jet was visible as it plunged through a cloud layer and came out—right over the tall buildings of downtown Brooklyn.

Oh no, Peter thought. If the plane crashed there, how many people would be killed?

The Vulture also saw that the plane was going to crash. He tore open the roof and dropped inside, trying to salvage

something before the whole operation would go up in smoke...literally.

Peter jumped onto the plane's tail and shot out a web to the right wing. He pulled on it for all he was worth, trying to force the plane to bank away from the populated area. "Please turn, please turn," he begged, and the plane seemed to answer.

The wingtip lifted just enough to miss the skyscrapers, and the jet angled toward Coney Island. Its left wing smashed through the top of one of the rides, and a moment later, it plowed into the beach. A huge plume of sand exploded into the night sky as the jet skidded for hundreds of yards, shedding pieces of itself and bursting into flame.

Spider-Man was thrown free as the wreckage crashed all around him. He hit the wet sand hard and tumbled, finally rolling to a halt at the edge of the flaming crash site. He sat up, his goggles fouled with sand. He took the suit's mask off so he could see better. All around him, fires burned in the sand. Crates of priceless artifacts and technology lay scattered and broken.

If the Vulture had been on the plane, Peter didn't see how he could have survived.

Just as he had that thought, the Vulture flashed out of the wreckage and slammed Peter back onto the sand. "Hey, Pedro," he said, and came after Peter again. Peter dodged him once, twice, and then the Vulture soared up above him, and Peter caught him with a web. But the Vulture was onto that trick. He shot straight up into the air, dragging Peter

with him. The wing suit smoked and whined, badly damaged in the crash, but the Vulture was beyond caring. He cut Peter's web and let him drop, then followed to smash him down into the ground with his talons. Peter tried to fight back, but the Vulture had him. He jumped up and down, holding Peter in his talons and stomping him into the ground until Peter lay limp.

Then he used his wing tip to pick up Peter by the loose hood of the Spider-Man suit and stared at him, deciding how to finish him off.

Over Peter's shoulder, something caught Toomes's attention. A crate. He took off his helmet because its sensors were malfunctioning and got a better look. The crate was filled with arc reactors like the one powering the Iron Man armor. That by itself would be enough to set Toomes up for life.

He dropped Spider-Man and bird-hopped over to the crate, then seized it in his talons and tried to lift it off the ground. The wing suit sparked, and flames spat from its engines. It was badly damaged from the fight and the crash, but Toomes wasn't going to stop now. He strained, and the crate started to lift free of the sand.

Peter stirred, regaining his senses. The first thing he saw was purple energy leaking from one of the Vulture's wing engines. "Your suit!" he shouted over the shriek of the engines. "It's gonna explode!"

Peter could see in Toomes's face that he didn't care. He had come too far to stop now. He was going to get that crate or

die trying. Peter struggled to his feet and webbed one side of the Vulture suit. Toomes slashed the web off with a bladed wing tip. Peter tried again, and Toomes cut himself free again. “Time to go home, Pete!” he snarled.

“I’m trying to save you!” Peter shouted back. He tried to web the suit again, but his web shooter just clicked. It was empty.

Toomes groaned and forced his suit engines into overdrive. One of them started to shoot fire, but he kept going. The crate was nearly clear of the sand now. Toomes kept lifting it, and he drifted back over the crashed plane. In a blinding flash, the burning wing engine flamed out. The crate crashed back down to the beach, and the Vulture went with it—right into the flaming wreckage of the plane. An explosion boomed out as he hit the ground.

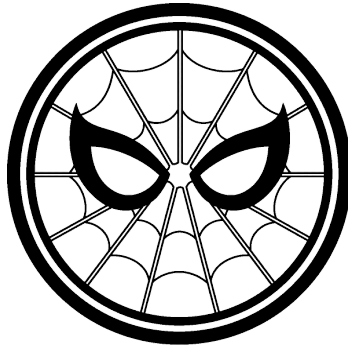
“No!” Peter yelled. He ran to the burning wreckage and looked for a path through. There. If the Vulture suit could protect Toomes, just for a minute...

He plunged in.

A long moment later, he emerged from the firestorm, carrying Toomes over his shoulders. He staggered to a safe distance from the crash site and laid Toomes in the sand. Toomes, bloodied and defeated, locked eyes with Peter. “You should have let me die.”

“I couldn’t,” Peter said. It was simple. “That’s not who I am.”

He heard the wail of sirens. It was time for Spider-Man to get out of there.



Happy Hogan led a team of Damage Control agents through the crash site. This was a disaster. The Vulture was still out there, and a whole planeload of stored tech was either destroyed or in the hands of bad guys. Happy knew Stark was going to fire him, and he also knew that he would deserve it. Somehow he'd let the jet get hijacked, and the consequences were going to be worse than dire. He searched the wreckage, pointing out things for the crews to salvage. Around him, the Damage Control agents were setting up a perimeter.

His flashlight beam found something out of the ordinary. It looked like a spiderweb.

No way, Happy thought. He followed the web to a tangle against a crate full of Ultron heads. Wrapped up in the tangle was a semiconscious man in a singed leather jacket. Stuck to the crate near him was a short note: *Found Vulture Guy—Spider-Man*.

He looked up to the highest thing nearby, wondering if the kid was still around. The lights on the Cyclone roller coaster

blinked on and off, and Happy had a feeling maybe someone up there was watching.

That kid , Happy thought. They had underestimated him.



Chapter 27



At school the next day, Peter looked around at all the kids living normal lives. Liz was absent. The whole school was buzzing with the news that her father had been some kind of costumed maniac who tried to destroy an Avengers plane. That was the version of the story that had gotten out. Spider-Man was mentioned, too, but nobody seemed sure what role he had played.

Except Ned, who kept reliving his role in the events. After school, he and Peter walked down the hall toward the Decathlon team meeting. “It was so crazy. You were like, *aaaaahhhh!* And I was like, *pfew!* And the web just nailed that guy! So crazy,” Ned said excitedly for maybe the tenth time since the morning.

Peter nodded. “You saved me.”

Then he saw Liz and her mother, walking out of the principal’s office, and he forgot all about what Ned was saying. Betty ran up to Liz and gave her a hug. When Betty moved on, Peter called out. “Hey, Liz.”

She saw him and looked away as he came closer. “Listen, I’m so sorry,” he said, feeling like he was always apologizing to her. But it was the least he could do.

“You say that a lot,” she said, looking at him with tears in her eyes. “What are you sorry for this time?”

He couldn’t really answer that.

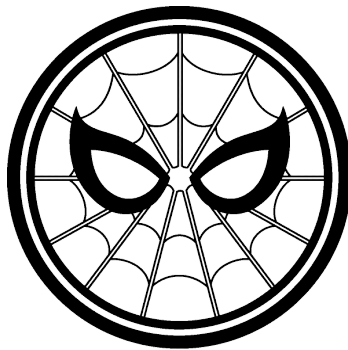
“The dance?” she suggested. “That was a pretty crappy thing to do.”

“Yeah, but...your dad, I can’t imagine what you’re going through. If there’s anything I can do to help...” He trailed off.

“I guess we’re moving to Oregon,” she said. “Mom says it’s nice there, so that’s cool. Anyway, Dad doesn’t want us here during the trial.”

“Liz, I—”

“Bye, Peter. Whatever’s going on with you, I hope you figure it out,” she said. Then she walked away with her mother. All Peter could do was watch her go, and then make his way down the hall toward the Decathlon meeting. Being a Super Hero wasn’t always all it was cracked up to be.



“Congratulations, Decathlon national champions!” Mr. Harrington announced. He set the trophy on the table, and the assembled Decathletes applauded. “I’m going to have to put this back in the trophy case soon, but just for motivation...I’m a little ahead of the game right now, but we will need a new team captain next year, so I am appointing Michelle.”

Everyone looked at Michelle, who blinked in surprise.

“Thank you,” she said. “My friends call me MJ.”

“Thought you didn’t have any friends,” Ned said.

“I...didn’t,” she said, and looked shyly around the room as the rest of the team applauded again.

Peter’s phone buzzed with a text from an unknown number. *Go to the bathroom.*

He looked up. “Uh, sorry, I gotta go.”

“Where are you going?” Michelle asked. “What are you hiding, Peter?” She stared at him, and he started to feel like he was caught in some kind of trap he hadn’t known was there. Then she laughed. “Just kidding; I don’t care. Go.”

Peter headed for the bathroom, but he knew she was watching him go.

He got another surprise when he walked into the bathroom and saw Happy Hogan standing next to the row of sinks. “Hey, Happy,” he said uncertainly. “What are...uh, what are you doing here?”

“I really owe you one,” Happy said sincerely. “I don’t know what I’d do without this job. I mean, before I met Tony—”

He was interrupted by a flush from one of the stalls. A kid named Tiny came out and washed his hands while Peter and Happy stood uncomfortably, waiting for him to leave. Tiny gave them both a dubious look, but he didn’t say anything. When he was gone, Peter said, “So how long have you been in here?”

“Long enough for it to be awkward,” Happy said. “Boss wants to see you.”

Peter pointed at one of the stalls and whispered, “Is he in here, too?”

“In the toilet? No. He’s upstate.” Happy headed for the door.

“Upstate?” Peter repeated. “Like upstate upstate?” Meaning, at the new Avengers HQ upstate? Is that where Tony Stark wanted to see him?

“Yeah,” Happy said. “Let’s go.”

Amazed at this sudden turn of fortune, Peter followed him.



Chapter 28



Three hours later he was staring out the car window in amazement. The car was driving itself, and Happy turned around in the driver's seat. "Take a look. It's pretty

impressive, huh? They just finished remodeling the whole thing.”

The new Avengers compound was gleaming and futuristic in the bright afternoon sunshine. The car drove down a perimeter road that gave Peter a good look at the main building, the Quinjet landing compound, and what looked like research labs on the other side of the complex....He thought his eyes might pop out of his head, but he kept looking.

It was really happening. He was going to be an Avenger.

Or was he? Peter didn't want to assume. Maybe Tony Stark just wanted to give him a medal or a scholarship or something. But whatever happened, it was going to be worth it just to see this place. A Quinjet was taking off as they waited in the spacious glass atrium. “Don't see that every day,” Happy commented.

“Oh, there they are!” said Tony Stark, coming down the main stairs into the atrium. “How was the ride up?”

“Good,” Happy said.

Tony nodded. “Give me a minute with the kid.”

“Seriously?” Happy couldn't believe this was happening again.

“Yeah. I gotta talk to the kid.”

“I'll be close behind,” Happy said.

“How about a loose follow? Boundaries are good.” Tony dropped an arm over Peter’s shoulders and walked him away. Happy trailed behind.

“Sorry I took your suit,” Stark said. “I mean, you had it coming. Actually, turns out it was the perfect sort of tough-love moment that you needed, right? To urge you on. Don’t you think?”

“I guess?” Peter wasn’t sure, but he didn’t want to disagree with Tony Stark. At least until he knew what was happening.

“Let’s just say it was.”

“Look, Mr. Stark. I know I—” He was about to apologize again. Sometimes it seemed like all Peter ever did was say he was sorry to people....But this time Stark didn’t give him a chance.

“Screwed the pooch,” Tony said. “Big-time. But you did the right thing, took the dog to the free clinic, raised the hybrid puppies—” He caught himself. “All right, not my best analogy. I was wrong about you, Peter. With a little more... mentoring...you could be a real asset to the team.”

“To the...to the team?” Peter stammered. It was happening. It was happening!

“Yeah.” They had reached the far side of the atrium. Stark pointed at a door. “Anyway, there’s about fifty reporters behind that door. Real ones, not bloggers.” He tapped his

watch, and a section of the wall in front of them slid open, revealing a gleaming new Spider-Suit.

“When you’re ready, why don’t you try that on, and I’ll introduce them to the newest official member of the Avengers—Spider-Man.”

Peter was speechless. All he could do was stare at the suit and try to breathe. He was making sounds, but they weren’t words. The suit was fantastic, newer and fancier even than the one he’d been wearing before Stark took it away. This was the dream. And it was coming true.

“After the press conference, Happy will show you your room. You’re next door to”—he glanced over at Happy for confirmation—“to Vision?”

“Fair warning,” Happy said. “He’s not big on doors. Or walls.”

“You’ll fit right in,” Stark joked.

Peter looked at the suit and considered what it meant. If he put it on and went out in front of all those reporters, his life would change forever. He wouldn’t be Peter Parker at Midtown anymore. He would be Spider-Man, living with the Avengers, going on amazing adventures to save the world...a dream. This was what he had wanted ever since Stark had first found him and taken him to Germany.

But Peter was also thinking about Ned...and about how he had hurt Liz without meaning to...and about May, who would be all alone without him. Now that the dream was

within his grasp, he started to realize that maybe it wasn't what he had thought it was. Toomes had gotten carried away with his vision of power. Peter had tried to help and nearly gotten a bunch of people killed. Was he ready for this?

Was he ready to leave everything, trade in his old life for a new one as an Avenger?

He squared his shoulders and turned away from the suit to face Tony Stark. "Thank you, Mr. Stark," he said. "But I'm good."

"You're good?" Stark echoed. Peter could see he was squinting at him behind his tinted glasses, like he wasn't quite sure what he was hearing. "How are you good?"

"I mean...I'd rather just stay on the ground for a while. Friendly neighborhood Spider-Man. Someone's gotta look out for the little guy, right?"

Stark took off his glasses. "You turning me down? You better think about it." He pointed at the suit. "Look at that." When Peter did, he said, "Look at me."

Peter did. "Last chance, yes or no," Stark said.

"No," Peter said.

Peter could tell that Tony Stark was not used to people telling him no. But he went with it. "Okay. Fair enough. Has a working-class-hero kind of vibe that I dig." Tony looked over at Happy. "Okay, Happy will take you home."

“Yeah,” Happy said. “Mind waiting out at the car? I need a minute.”

“Okay.” Peter shook Tony’s hand and said, “Thank you, Mr. Stark.”

“Yes,” Stark said, and after a pause: “Mr. Parker.”

“I’ll see you around,” Peter added. He felt like a great weight had been lifted from him, and he couldn’t help smiling as he walked away. Then, after a few steps, a thought occurred to him. He stopped. “That was a test, right?” he asked, indicating the door. “There’s nobody back there.”

“Yes,” Tony said. “You passed. All right, skedaddle there.”

“Thanks, Mr. Stark!” Peter headed for the door.

“Told you he was a good kid,” Happy said quietly. Tony just watched him go.

A moment later, the door opened. The room on the other side was crammed with reporters and cameras. It hadn’t been a test; Tony had just cut the kid a break. With everything else going on in his life, he didn’t need the pressure.

Pepper Potts stepped in and shut the door behind her.

“Where’s the kid? Everyone’s waiting.”

“He left,” Happy said.

“You know what?” Tony said. “He actually made a really mature choice. Just surprised the heck out of us.”

Pepper glared at Tony. “Did you guys screw this up? Are you kidding me? I have a room full of people in there waiting for some big announcement. What am I going to tell them?”

“Think of something,” Tony said. “How about, um...Hap, you still have that ring?”

“Are you kidding?” Happy fished around in his pocket and came up with an engagement ring. Its diamonds caught the light. “I’ve been carrying it since 2008.”

Tony looked to Pepper, who had a strange expression on her face, like she wasn’t sure what else might have been in Happy’s pocket with the ring all those years.

“Well, it would buy us some time,” Tony said. Pepper gave him a kiss and then headed back toward the briefing room. “I can’t believe you let the kid get away...”

Tony rushed to hold the door for her. He glanced back at Happy, who tossed him the ring. He took it and followed her into the room. The reporters were going to get a story one way or another.



Chapter 29



Peter was feeling pretty good about himself by the time Happy dropped him off back in Queens. He strolled through the front door and into his room, knowing he'd turned his back on a life of crazy, awesome adventures and also knowing it had been the right thing to do. He could still help people right here, in his neighborhood. The people the Avengers couldn't help because they were too busy saving the world.

On his bed he noticed something that hadn't been there when he left that morning. It was a brown paper bag with the words *NO FRILLS PROTOCOL* scrawled on it in black marker.

Someone had been in his room? How...?

"May?" he called.

She didn't answer. Peter opened the bag.

Inside was the Spider-Suit. Not the new one, but the one he'd been wearing until Stark took it away from him after the ferry incident.

Peter's heart jumped in his chest. This was incredible! He had turned down an offer to join the Avengers, and Tony Stark wasn't even mad! Maybe he'd meant it when he said Peter should be a friendly neighborhood Spider-Man. In any case, he had made sure Peter could do it. He put the suit on and started fooling around with it...and also just enjoying the feeling of being Spider-Man. He peeled off the mask and looked down at himself with a big grin. This was

going to be his life. Not an Avenger, but maybe a Super Hero anyway. The best of both worlds.

In his excitement, he spun around—and saw May, standing in his doorway and staring in shock.

Oh man , Peter thought. This was going to be hard to explain.

EPILOGUE ◀



Adrian Toomes walked down the prison hallway on his way to visitation. It was going to be the last time he saw his family for a while, but they were safe, and that was what mattered.

Ahead of him, he saw Mac Gargan and two of his goons. The ferry caper had put all of them in jail for a long time. “Hey, look who it is,” Gargan said. His scorpion tattoo curled up from the collar of his prison jumpsuit. He managed to be both friendly and threatening at the same time. “Toomes. What are the odds we’d go to the same summer camp?”

Toomes didn’t say anything. If Gargan blamed him for getting arrested, there was going to be trouble. And if there

was going to be trouble, Toomes was going to let someone else start it.

“Relax.” Gargan laughed. “This ain’t on you. It’s on our little spider friend.” He stepped closer and dropped his voice. “I heard a rumor you know who he is. My boys on the outside would love to meet him.”

Toomes hesitated. Spider-Man had put him here. But Spider-Man had also saved his life...and saved Liz’s life. “If I knew who he was,” Toomes said, “he’d already be dead.”

Gargan took a step back. He looked disappointed and suspicious. Toomes figured there was going to be trouble after all, but not right away. “Toomes!” a guard called. “Your family’s here! Let’s go!”

He walked into the visitation area. Doris and Liz stood as he came in. Doris looked angry, sad, also happy...all the confused emotions you could feel toward someone you loved. Liz was crying. She was just a kid. She couldn’t understand what the next few years were going to be like.

“Hey, Gumdrops,” he said.

She wiped at her eyes and said, “Hey, Dad.” Toomes wrapped his arms around his daughter, smiling to himself. After everything, she was still alive. He might be in prison, but he still had his daughter.

Thanks to Spider-Man.

